

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · July 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	80.7
#2	A+	Charlotte	73.3
#3	A+	Atlanta	70.6
#4	A+	Kansas City	70.4
#5	A+	Cincinnati	69.3
#6	A+	Nashville	69.1
#7	A	Salt Lake City	66.0

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	19.9
#49	D	Louisville	20.2
#48	D	Grand Rapids	21.1
#47	C-	Chicago	28.5
#46	C-	Minneapolis	29.9
#45	C-	Detroit	30.8
#44	C-	Richmond	31.7

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	11 cities
B+ / B / B-	24 cities
C+ / C / C-	12 cities
D	3 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · July 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	80.7	3.0%	+4.2%	+2.2%	+0.6%	50 days
2	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	73.3	3.6%	+3.9%	+1.4%	+0.3%	51 days
3	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	70.6	3.2%	+4.3%	+0.0%	+1.6%	52 days
4	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	70.4	3.5%	+8.3%	+0.2%	-0.7%	45 days
5	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	69.3	3.1%	+5.4%	+0.5%	-1.0%	37 days
6	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	69.1	2.8%	+7.2%	+0.3%	-0.8%	53 days
7	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	66.0	3.4%	+4.1%	+2.1%	-0.1%	50 days
8	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.5	2.7%	+3.4%	+1.9%	+2.8%	29 days
9	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A	65.0	3.5%	+1.0%	+1.5%	-0.8%	37 days
10	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	63.5	3.5%	+5.7%	+1.1%	+0.4%	63 days
11	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	61.3	3.8%	+6.5%	-0.5%	+2.0%	47 days
12	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B+	58.9	3.9%	+7.8%	+0.8%	-1.4%	43 days
13	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	56.1	5.3%	+5.0%	+2.1%	+1.3%	55 days
14	New York New York-Newark-Jersey City	B	54.0	4.3%	+4.5%	+0.5%	+0.5%	47 days
15	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	53.6	4.4%	+4.2%	+1.2%	+1.1%	70 days
16	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	52.6	4.8%	+7.2%	+0.0%	-0.3%	37 days
17	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	52.3	3.6%	+6.5%	+0.3%	-1.8%	37 days
18	Cleveland Cleveland	B	51.3	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
19	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	51.2	4.0%	+2.1%	+0.6%	+0.2%	51 days
20	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B	50.7	3.6%	+7.5%	-0.3%	-0.9%	82 days
21	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	50.6	4.1%	-0.1%	+0.2%	+1.5%	39 days
22	Columbus Columbus	B	50.0	2.7%	+3.6%	+0.2%	-1.5%	39 days
23	Fresno Fresno	B-	49.9	7.4%	+5.2%	+2.0%	0.0%	55 days
24	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	49.0	4.6%	+2.0%	+0.6%	+0.0%	50 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	48.8	4.8%	+4.2%	+1.8%	-1.9%	50 days
26	Memphis Memphis	B-	48.6	4.1%	+7.7%	-0.1%	-1.1%	64 days
27	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	48.4	3.2%	+0.4%	+0.6%	-0.8%	54 days
28	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	47.9	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.3%	-0.7%	44 days
29	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	45.8	4.5%	+5.9%	-0.0%	-0.3%	68 days
30	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.1	3.6%	+1.9%	-0.6%	-2.6%	48 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	45.0	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	32 days
32	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	44.9	4.2%	+6.5%	-0.5%	-1.1%	51 days
33	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B-	44.6	3.9%	+4.2%	-0.7%	-0.2%	36 days
34	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	44.5	4.1%	+2.5%	+1.0%	-1.3%	64 days
35	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	44.1	3.9%	+3.5%	-0.4%	+2.9%	37 days
36	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.9	3.7%	+6.1%	-1.0%	-1.3%	37 days
37	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	42.9	3.2%	+1.3%	-0.9%	-0.1%	33 days
38	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	41.5	3.0%	+0.4%	-1.1%	-0.2%	45 days
39	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C+	40.7	4.6%	+5.7%	-0.1%	-2.3%	59 days
40	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	40.3	3.9%	+5.3%	-3.0%	-2.7%	36 days
41	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	37.1	4.1%	+1.2%	+0.4%	-0.1%	61 days
42	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.7	4.7%	+6.4%	-2.8%	-1.1%	51 days
43	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	35.0	4.2%	+1.2%	+0.6%	-1.5%	43 days
44	Richmond Richmond	C-	31.7	3.5%	+3.0%	-0.9%	-1.0%	37 days
45	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	30.8	5.5%	+1.7%	-0.8%	+2.2%	38 days
46	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	29.9	3.9%	+0.5%	+0.3%	-1.4%	37 days
47	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	28.5	4.9%	+3.6%	-0.0%	-1.7%	33 days
48	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	21.1	4.4%	+2.7%	-0.6%	-6.2%	33 days
49	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	20.2	4.6%	+1.8%	-0.8%	-1.0%	40 days
50	Jacksonville Jacksonville	D	19.9	4.7%	-0.2%	-0.4%	-0.1%	59 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

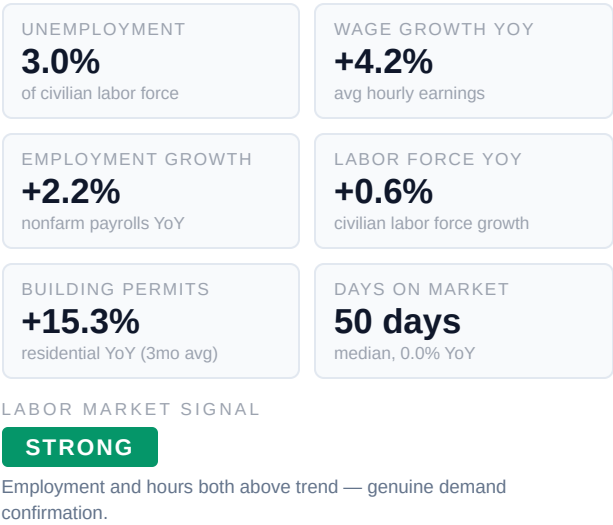
80.7th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 80.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.84, and its strong office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.54. The labor demand is driven by a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.930% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area exhibits a strong labor demand, with a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.930% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with workers putting in more hours to meet the growing demand. The labor demand composite score of 8.84 further reinforces this trend, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.00%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the available workforce is scarce, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. With an unemployment rate percentile rank of 88th, the city's labor market is characterized by a high level of employment, making it a competitive environment for businesses looking to hire.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 4.25%, which is moderate and indicates a stable labor cost environment. While this wage growth is not exceptionally high, it still suggests that workers have some bargaining power, and businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages accordingly. The 58th percentile rank for wage growth indicates that the city's wage growth is near the median, neither exceptionally high nor low.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 84th, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$218/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$38.42, results in a ratio of 5.67, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.58% year-over-year, indicating a moderate expansion of the workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city's labor pool is increasing, providing businesses with a slightly larger talent pool to draw from. However, the 78th percentile rank for labor force growth indicates that the city's workforce expansion is not exceptionally rapid.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 15.33% year-over-year, signaling an expansion of the city's housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city is likely to experience improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future. The 76th percentile rank for building permits indicates that the city's housing supply is growing at a rate above the national average.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 50 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the 30th percentile rank for days on market suggests that the city's housing market is actually relatively competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. This fast-paced market may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or adjust their hiring timelines accordingly.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with a percentile rank of 98th, indicating that it is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.54, makes it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's tight labor market and competitive housing market may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and relocate workers, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering Raleigh-Cary as a potential location.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

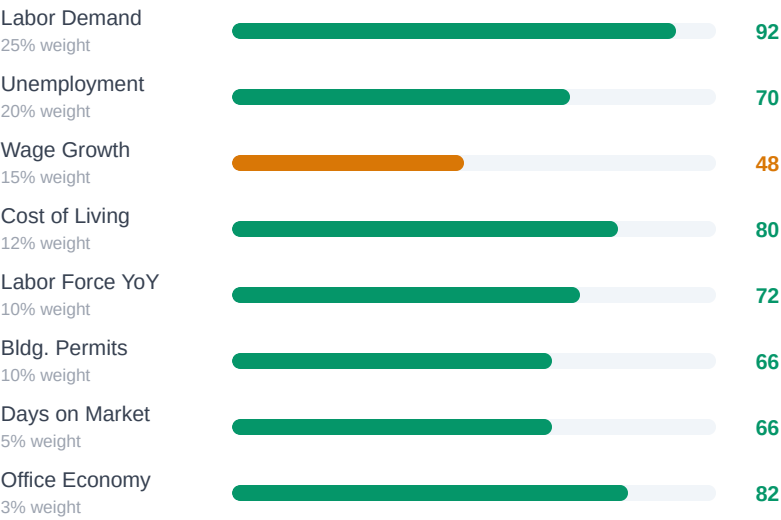
A+

EXCELLENT

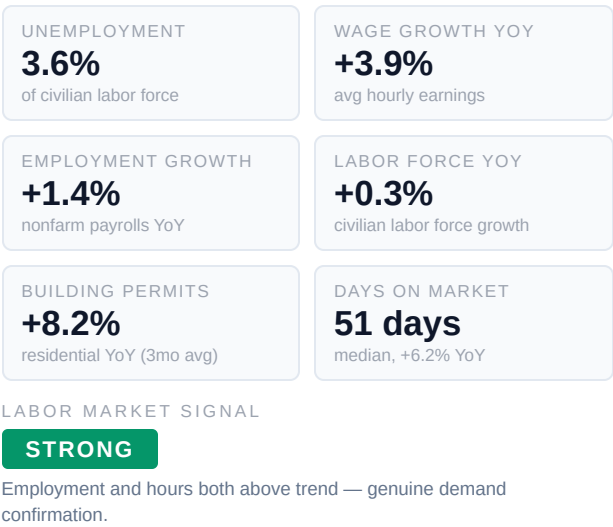
73.3th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.16, and its above-average cost of living, with a percentile rank of 80th. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and a relatively affordable cost of living.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen employment growth of 1.37% year-over-year, combined with a 0.945% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs and hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 7.16, ranked in the 92nd percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.60%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, although not extremely so. For businesses trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, there is still some competition for skilled workers.

Wage Growth

The city has seen year-over-year wage growth of 3.91%, ranking in the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. As a result, workers in the area are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, although it is not exceptionally strong.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 80th, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$221/sqft, which has decreased by 1.3% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly wage of \$38.36, results in a ratio of 5.76. This affordability makes the city an attractive location for talent, as businesses do not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by 0.32% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is not extremely strong, it still suggests that the city's labor pool is increasing, making it slightly easier for businesses to find new talent.

Building Permits

The city has seen an 8.18% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 66th percentile. This rise in permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should help improve affordability and accommodate the city's growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.2%. This suggests a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising days on market also indicates a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 82nd, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant industries.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the moderate unemployment rate, which may lead to some competition for skilled workers and upward pressure on wages.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

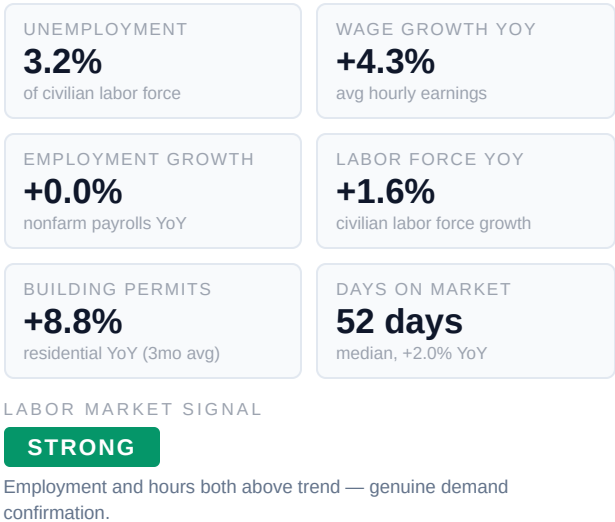
70.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.6th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.35, and its low unemployment rate of 3.20%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and a tight labor pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is 0.03% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +1.004% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.35, ranking in the 70th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. With such a low unemployment rate, the practical implication for a business trying to hire in Atlanta is that it may need to be prepared to offer higher salaries or benefits to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Atlanta is +4.31%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but can also expect to benefit from a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$198/sqft to \$36.88/hr, Atlanta ranks in the 71st percentile in terms of affordability, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The affordability of Atlanta makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.58% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This growth suggests that businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential workers, making it

easier to hire and staff new positions. The implication for hiring capacity is positive, with a growing labor force providing a steady stream of new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing at a rate of +8.79% year-over-year, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This growth in permits suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which should lead to an expansion of housing supply and improved affordability in the future. As a result, businesses can expect that their workers will have access to a range of housing options, making it easier for them to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Atlanta is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.0%, ranking in the 50th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, with homes selling at a moderate pace. For a worker relocating to Atlanta, this means that they will have a reasonable amount of time to find a new home, without feeling rushed or facing intense competition.

Office Economy

With an office economy composite score ranking in the 66th percentile, Atlanta has a deep talent pool of professional and office workers, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which may require a different type of workforce. The presence of a strong office economy makes Atlanta an attractive location for businesses looking to establish or expand their headquarters or professional services operations.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, low unemployment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for a tight labor market to drive up wages and make it challenging to attract and retain top talent, which could impact business costs and competitiveness.

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

70.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		54
25% weight		
Unemployment		80
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		82
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		48
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		92
10% weight		
Days on Market		30
5% weight		
Office Economy		30
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +8.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +51.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 45 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 8.26% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which together signal a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest that Kansas City is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.25% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.049% above its own 12-month baseline, indicates a moderate expansion of labor demand. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.70 corresponds to a near-median percentile rank of 54th, suggesting a stable but not exceptionally strong labor market.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.50% is notably low, corresponding to a top-tier percentile rank of 80th. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies looking to staff up in Kansas City may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 8.26%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid wage inflation, ranking it in the 98th percentile. This fast wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers will have increased purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. As a result, companies should factor in higher labor costs when considering a location in Kansas City.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$197/sqft and an hourly wage of \$35.77, corresponds to a ratio of 5.51, ranking it in the 82nd percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.0% year-over-year, however, may indicate some upward pressure on housing costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is contracting at a rate of -0.70% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in the city.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of 51.78%, ranking it in the 92nd percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, Kansas City is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City is 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This corresponds to a below-average percentile rank of 30th, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a competitive housing market, with homes selling quickly.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share corresponds to a percentile rank of 30th, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. As a result, the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more attractive to industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with exceptional wage growth and low unemployment, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce. However, the city's shrinking labor force and competitive housing market may pose challenges for hiring and talent attraction, and businesses should carefully consider these factors when making a location decision. Overall, Kansas City's strengths make it a compelling choice for businesses, but its weaknesses require careful planning and strategy to overcome.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

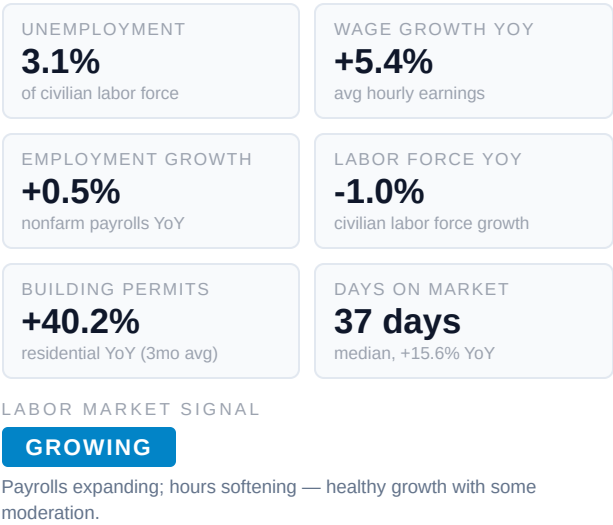
69.3th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 69.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its strong wage growth of +5.40% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.45% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, but hours worked are slightly below the 12-month baseline. This indicates genuine demand expansion, rather than a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there is less slack in the workforce. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wages in Cincinnati are growing at a rate of +5.40% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Companies should factor in these rising costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score ranking at the 86th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$194/sqft to \$35.49/hr, or 5.47. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. As a result, businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Companies should plan accordingly and consider strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are increasing at a rate of +40.25% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and accommodation for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect

a more stable and growing pool of potential employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +15.6%, ranking at the 96th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city may have an easier time finding housing, as homes are sitting on the market for longer periods. However, this may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share ranks at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent in these sectors. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses that require a general workforce, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech, finance, or consulting talent.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable living costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may pose challenges for hiring and talent attraction in the long term.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

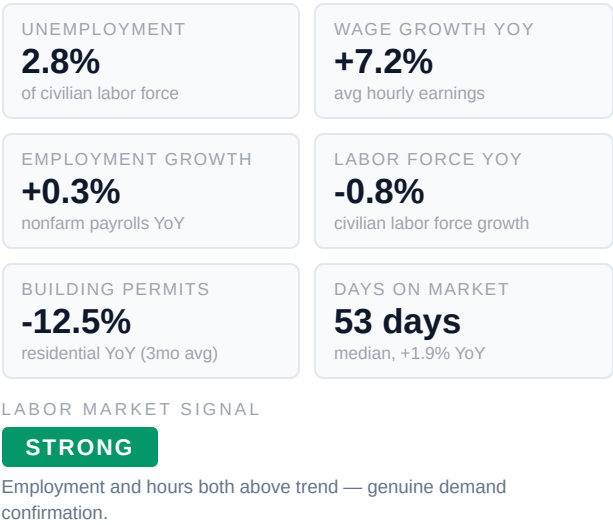
69.1th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking it at the 69.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier (80th percentile), and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, ranking it in the top tier (88th percentile). These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and intense competition for labor.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is +0.35% year-over-year, combined with a +0.942% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.73 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier (80th percentile).

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 2.80%, which is extremely low, ranking in the top tier (88th percentile). This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the city is +7.21%, which is very high, ranking in the top tier (88th percentile). This rapid wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for rising labor costs, but also recognize the benefits of a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score ranking it at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$260/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.31. While not extremely affordable, the city's cost of living is near the median, and the fact that PSF is falling by -1.1% year-over-year is a positive sign. This means that the city may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively manageable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is shrinking at a rate of -0.82% year-over-year, ranking in the near median (40th percentile). This contraction in the labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available

workers is decreasing. Businesses should be prepared to compete aggressively for talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The city has experienced a -12.54% year-over-year decline in residential building permits, ranking it below average (22nd percentile). This sharp decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.9%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the near median (48th percentile), means that the market is still competitive, but not extremely so. Workers relocating to the city may face some challenges in finding a home, but the market is not overly inaccessible.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking it in the top tier (86th percentile). This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a thriving job market with strong labor demand and low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as rising labor costs and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for affordability challenges and hiring difficulties due to the shrinking labor force and declining building permits, which may require businesses to adapt their strategies to attract and retain talent in this competitive environment.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

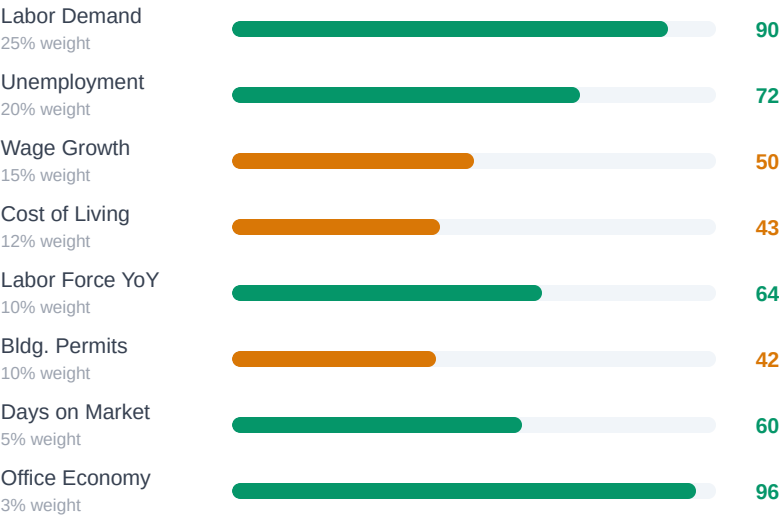
A

VERY GOOD

66.0th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep professional talent pool, as evidenced by a 90th percentile ranking in labor demand and a 96th percentile ranking in office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.80, combining a 2.12% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.467% deviation in weekly hours, suggests genuine demand expansion. With an unemployment rate of 3.40%, the market is relatively tight, which has implications for hiring and wage pressure.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.12% year-over-year employment growth rate, coupled with a -0.467% deviation in weekly hours, indicating that while jobs are being added, hours are slightly below trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, rather than a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The strong labor demand suggests a competitive market for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.40%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. For a company trying to hire in this market, being competitive on salary and benefits will be crucial.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the Salt Lake City-Murray metro area is 4.07%, placing it near the median in terms of wage growth among comparable cities. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not dramatically. This balance could support a stable business environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 43, Salt Lake City-Murray is near the median in terms of affordability, where the price per square foot is \$266 and the average hourly earnings are \$38.85, resulting in a ratio of 6.85. This indicates that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums solely to offset the cost of living, potentially easing the burden on labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by -0.06% year-over-year, ranking in the 64th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply suggests that the pool of potential workers is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and

business growth. Companies may need to be more competitive or look to alternative labor sources.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -4.56%, indicating that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to a supply squeeze. This trend signals that future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce could be at risk, making it essential for businesses to consider the long-term implications of housing availability on their operations and employee attractiveness.

Days on Market

Homes in Salt Lake City-Murray are currently sitting on the market for a median of 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.2%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it may indicate a more accessible and less competitive housing market. However, this also needs to be considered in the context of the overall job market and housing supply trends.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray boasts a deep and talented pool of professional workers, making it highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, given its strong orientation towards knowledge-economy jobs.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, which are significant advantages for companies looking to establish or expand operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, necessitating careful planning and consideration of long-term housing strategies for employees.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

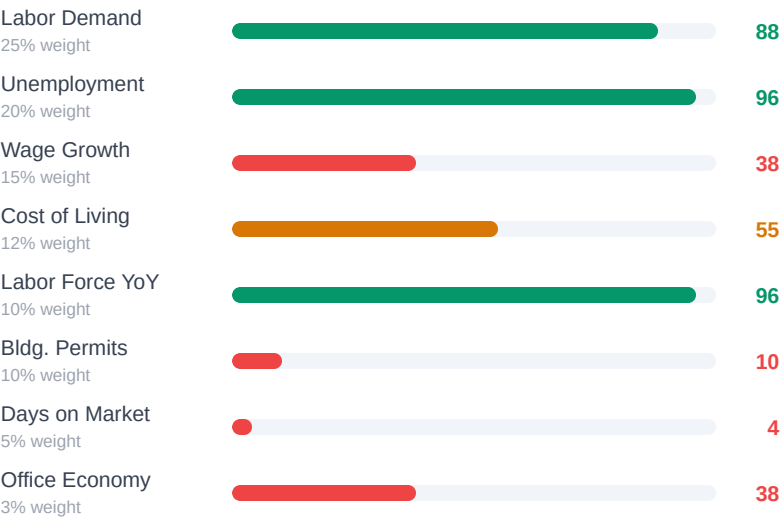
A

VERY GOOD

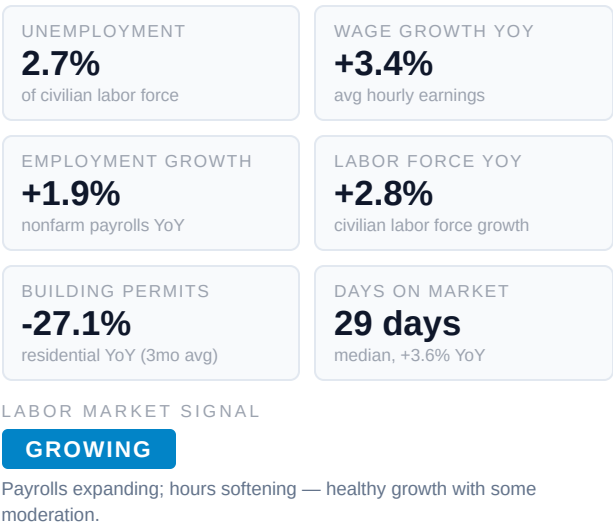
65.5th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 88th and 96th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 6.56 and unemployment rate of 2.70% signal a thriving job market. These metrics suggest that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with employment growth of 1.88% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.371% indicate a strong labor market, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, indicating a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.56 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 3.35% is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in the area will see some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be as significant as in other locations.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$254/sqft and hourly earnings of \$40.12, resulting in a ratio of 6.33, ranks in the 55th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. However, the 0.8% year-over-year increase in PSF may impact affordability in the future.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and staff operations. The strong labor force growth also signals a healthy and dynamic economy.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -27.06%, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decline in building permits may lead to increased competition for available housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.6%, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is not as competitive as in other areas. However, the slow market may also indicate weaker demand.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a composite score of 2.14, ranks in the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be more suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on office or professional workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, the city may still attract businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, albeit with some challenges in finding specialized talent.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, potentially impacting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

A

VERY GOOD

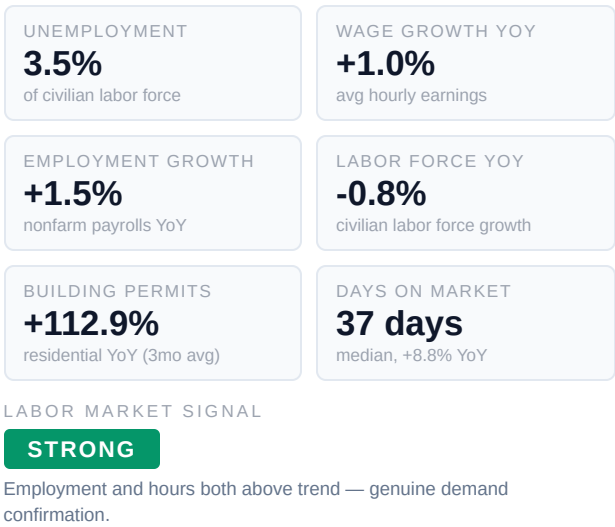
65.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a thriving office economy being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, driven by a 96th percentile labor demand composite score and an 84th percentile office/professional worker share. The city's labor demand is characterized by a 1.52% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.801% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. These numbers signal a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.93, driven by a 1.52% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.801% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend, indicating a strong and growing labor market. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend, suggesting a healthy and vibrant economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 96th percentile further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 3.50%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure and competition for talent. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.98%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers, which may impact worker purchasing power and overall consumer demand. The low percentile rank suggests that wage growth is a concern in this market.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living score that ranks in the 10th percentile, with a PSF of \$813/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$55.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 14.78, indicating an expensive market. However, the PSF is falling by 4.9% year-over-year, which is a key driver of affordability. Despite this, the city's high cost of living may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, making it challenging to maintain a competitive edge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is growing at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is shrinking, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. The near-median percentile rank suggests that labor force growth is a moderate concern in this market.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 112.94% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This surge in building permits signals a future improvement in affordability and workforce accommodation, as more housing units become available, which may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the labor market. The top-tier percentile rank reinforces this positive outlook.

Days on Market

The median days on market in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 37 days, with an 8.8% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. This slower market implies a more accessible and competitive environment for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find and secure housing. The top-tier percentile rank suggests that the market is favorable for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating a strong presence of tech, finance, and consulting industries. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce, but may be less suitable for industries that require a large, unskilled labor force. The high percentile rank reinforces the city's strengths in the office economy.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a thriving office economy, and a rapidly expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies that require a highly skilled workforce. However, the city's high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant risks and constraints, particularly for businesses that require a large, unskilled labor force or struggle to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

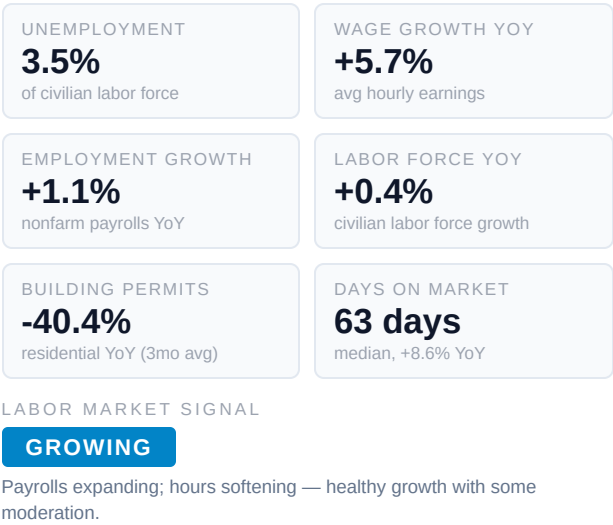
63.5th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low cost of living, scoring 64th and 96th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by its above-average employment growth rate of 1.06% and its top-tier cost of living ratio of 6.22, with PSF at \$237/sqft and hourly earnings at \$38.10/hr. This combination signals a highly competitive market with attractive conditions for both businesses and workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 1.06% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.642% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and, despite a slight decrease in hours worked, is experiencing a period of growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.14 further supports this, ranking in the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.50%, ranking in the 68th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the low availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong and stable workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 5.67%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers may rise, but it also means that workers will have greater purchasing power, contributing to a robust local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.22, driven by a PSF of \$237/sqft that is decreasing by 8.1% year-over-year relative to hourly earnings of \$38.10/hr, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos scores in the 96th percentile for affordability. This high ranking means the city is very attractive for talent without needing significant wage premiums, offering a competitive advantage in recruitment.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.44% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is likely to improve over time, as more workers become available.

Building Permits

The city has experienced a significant decline in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of -40.35%, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This sharp decrease signals a potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos are currently sitting on the market for 63 days, with an 8.6% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling fairly quickly, suggesting that workers may face challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 4.04, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep and talented pool of professional workers. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future housing affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting some of the city's current advantages.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

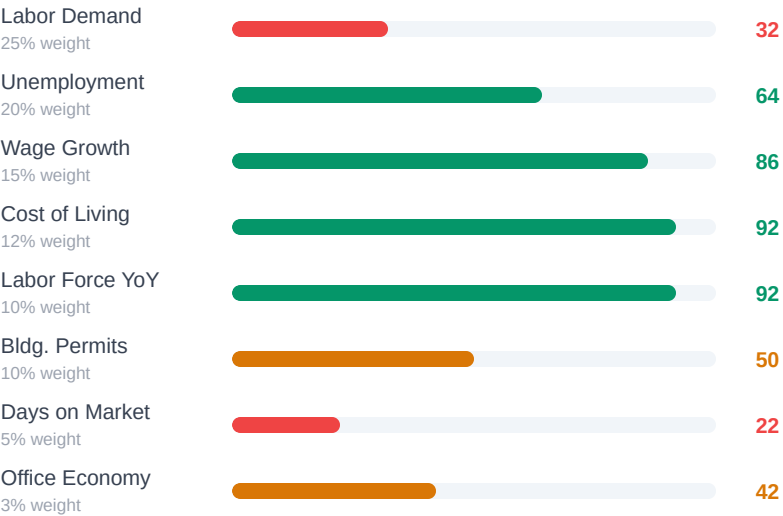
A-

GOOD

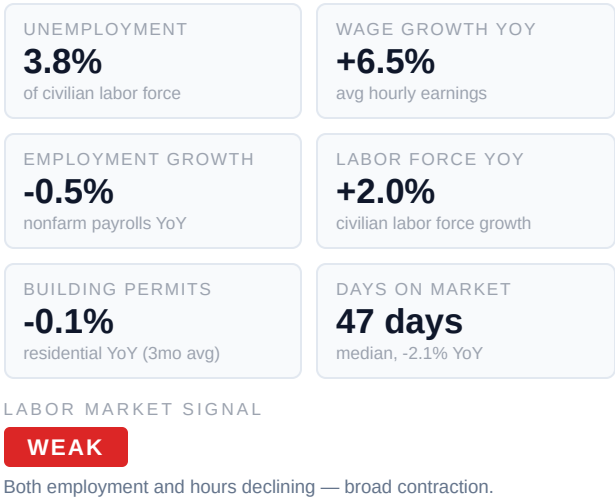
61.3th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.54%, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking at the 92th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market and rising labor costs, but also an attractive environment for talent due to its relative affordability.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.49% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.421% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not currently experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative hours deviation suggests that the remaining workforce may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than taking on new responsibilities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.54%, ranking at the 86th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services with their increasing earnings. However, it also poses a challenge for businesses, as they must adapt to a rising cost environment.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$174/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.14, ranking at the 92th percentile. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring substantial wage premiums. The city's affordability is a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.99% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing pool of available workers. Businesses can tap into this growing labor force to meet their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Pittsburgh is -0.14%, indicating a near-stable housing supply. This slight decline in permits may signal a potential tightening of the housing market, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. However, the current stability suggests that the city's housing market is not experiencing significant stress.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 47 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.1%. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The competitive market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent. The moderate ranking suggests that Pittsburgh can support a variety of business types, but may not be a hub for specific industries.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable cost of living, and expanding labor force supply. However, the city's tight labor market and rising labor costs pose a significant risk, as businesses must adapt to a competitive hiring environment and increasing wages to attract and retain top talent.

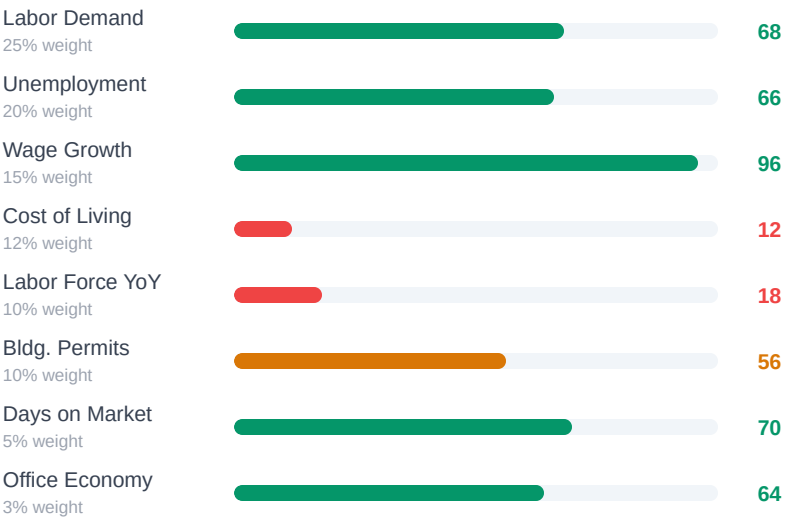
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

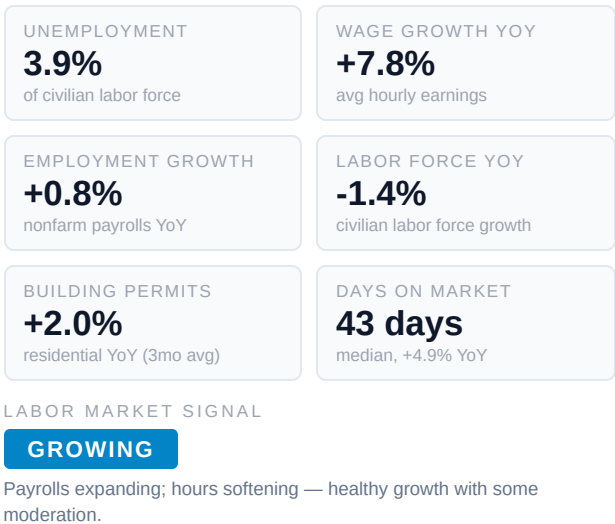
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.9th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.78% year-over-year and its above-average labor demand composite score of 5.29, which signals genuine demand expansion. The combination of these metrics suggests a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.85% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.202%, resulting in an above-average labor demand composite score. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor market is experiencing growth, indicating a positive environment for businesses.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 3.90%, ranking at the 66th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.78%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which is exceptionally high. This rapid wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers will have increased purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared to adapt to a rapidly changing labor market with rising costs.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking at the 12th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$604/sqft to \$43.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.97. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor supply will create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more difficult for businesses to find the talent they need. Companies should be prepared to invest in recruitment and retention strategies to overcome this challenge.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is increasing by 1.97% year-over-year, ranking at the 56th percentile. This moderate growth in housing supply is a positive sign, indicating that the city is taking steps to address affordability concerns. However, the pace of growth may not be sufficient to keep up with demand, and businesses should monitor the situation closely.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.9%, ranking at the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they will have more time to find a home. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 64th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce with more general skills.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the relatively high cost of living, which may require companies to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent. Despite this challenge, the city's top-tier wage growth and above-average labor demand make it an attractive location for businesses looking to establish or expand their operations.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

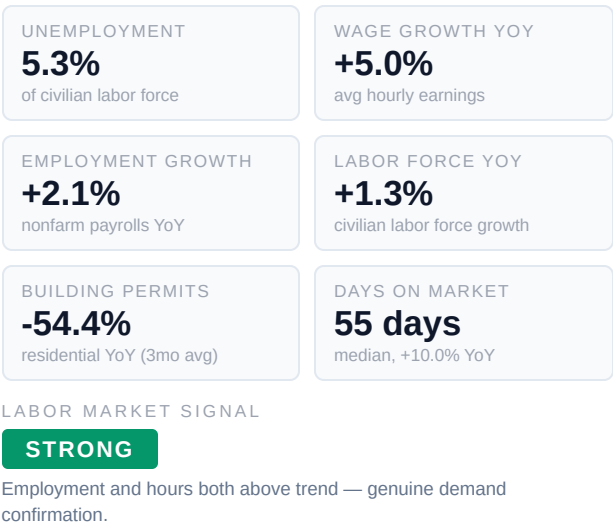
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.1th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 56.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, and its high office economy share, ranking at the 88th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.11% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.196% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.11% employment growth rate and a 0.196% increase in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The top-tier composite score of 94th percentile reinforces this interpretation, pointing to a strong labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.30%, ranking at the 14th percentile, which indicates a relatively loose labor market. This suggests that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 5.01%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power. The moderate pace of wage growth may help balance the needs of both employers and employees.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$264/sqft to \$33.11/hr, ranking at the 51st percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city offers a relatively neutral environment for talent attraction, neither requiring significant wage premiums to compensate for high costs nor offering a substantial advantage due to low costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area is growing at a rate of 1.33% year-over-year, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the labor pool is increasing, which is a favorable condition for hiring and business expansion. It implies that businesses can expect a growing talent pool from which to recruit.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -54.44%, ranking at the 0th percentile, which signals a sharp contraction in housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that the future housing supply is tightening, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This is a significant concern for businesses considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market stands at 55 days, with a 10.0% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 64th percentile. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less competitive over time. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but the rising days on market could signal a normalization towards a more balanced market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 88th percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which threatens future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially undermining the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

54.0th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		44
Wage Growth 15% weight		62
Cost of Living 12% weight		2
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		76
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		78
Days on Market 5% weight		12
Office Economy 3% weight		56

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +15.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, -4.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth, at 72nd and 76th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by its employment growth rate of 0.48% and weekly hours deviation of 0.430%, indicating genuine demand expansion. With a wage growth rate of 4.50%, the city also exhibits rising labor costs and increasing worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.48% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.430%, signaling genuine demand expansion as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.40 places the city in the 72nd percentile, confirming this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.30%, ranking in the 44th percentile, which suggests a near-median level of unemployment. This rate indicates that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, which could lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.50%, placing it in the 62nd percentile. This rate of wage growth is above average, signaling rising labor costs for employers. As a result, workers in the area are experiencing increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand but may pose challenges for businesses looking to control labor expenses.

Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$537/sqft to \$40.69/hr, with a PSF increase of 3.3% YoY, ranking it in the 2nd percentile for affordability. This low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of 0.45% year-over-year, placing it in the 76th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking

to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has seen a 15.42% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it in the 78th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, combined with the decreasing trend, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing quickly.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an office and professional worker share of 2.82, ranking in the 56th percentile. This near-median rank suggests a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city suited for a variety of businesses, including those in tech, finance, and consulting, but perhaps less ideal for industries requiring a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a dynamic environment with growing labor demand and an expanding workforce, but the high cost of living and competitive housing market pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively low affordability, which may necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, potentially impacting business operational costs.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

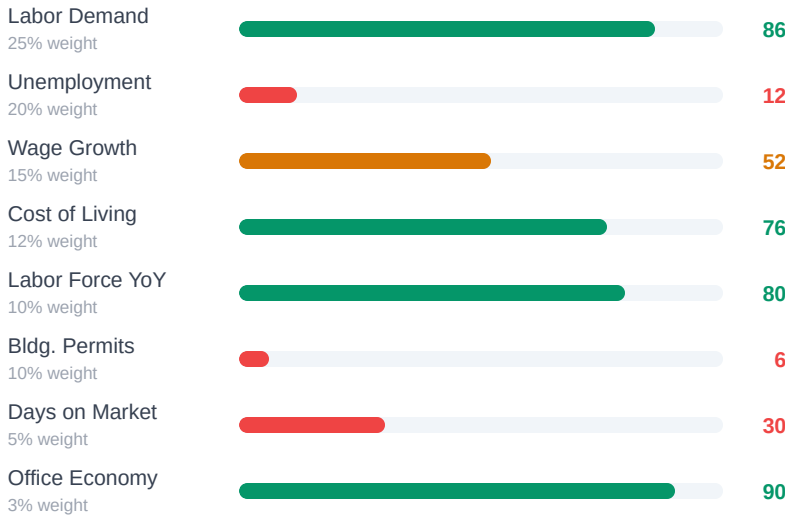
B

AVERAGE

53.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

70 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep professional talent pool. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.45, which combines a +1.22% employment growth rate and a +0.442% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its high office economy percentile rank, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area exhibits a +1.22% employment growth rate and a +0.442% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.45 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.40%, which corresponds to a bottom tier percentile rank of 12th, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as potential upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies looking to staff up in this city may need to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The city's year-over-year wage growth rate is +4.17%, placing it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. However, the relatively modest wage growth may not be sufficient to offset the potential hiring challenges posed by the tight labor market.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living percentile rank of 76th, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.64. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of +1.11% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to

staff up. A growing labor force can provide a steady pipeline of potential employees, reducing the likelihood of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have decreased by 29.77% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in permits may lead to future affordability challenges and potentially hinder the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential long-term implications of a constrained housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 70 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests a competitive market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the stable days on market metric indicates that the market is not becoming increasingly competitive, providing some relief for businesses looking to attract talent to the area.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 90th, indicating a strong presence of professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. Conversely, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the city's tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and hinder the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce, ultimately affecting businesses' ability to attract and retain top talent.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

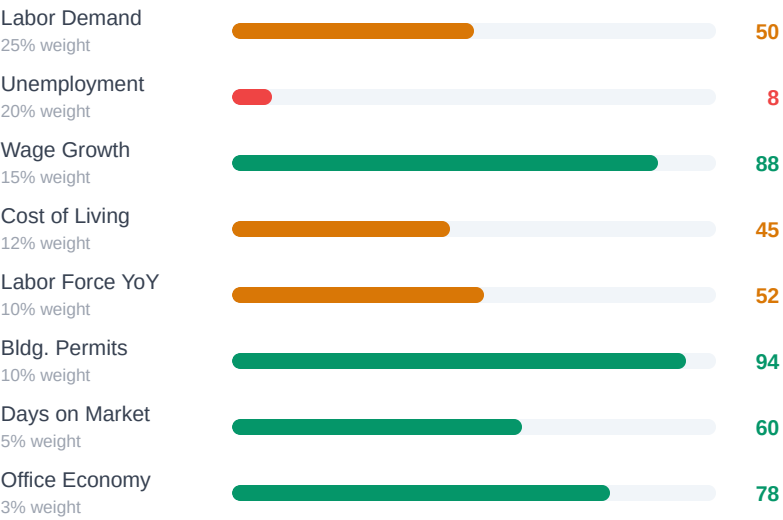
B

AVERAGE

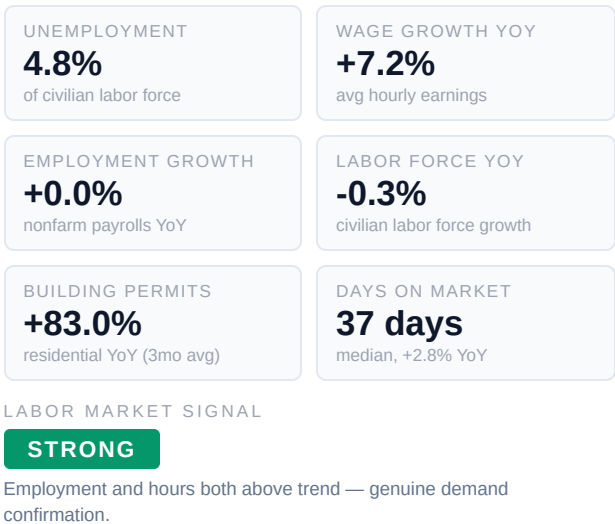
52.6th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.21% year-over-year and its strong building permits growth of 83.04% year-over-year, indicating a dynamic and expanding economy. These metrics suggest a city with a high demand for labor and a rapidly growing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.04% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.263% above its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.62 reflects this near-median performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.21%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, but may pose challenges for businesses looking to control labor costs. The high wage growth rate suggests a competitive labor market.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$444/sqft, which is decreasing by 3.5% year-over-year, and an earnings ratio of \$47.70/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.31, ranking near the median at the 45th percentile. This suggests that the city is moderately affordable, but not exceptionally so, which may impact talent attraction without wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a positive factor in the affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is growing at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This means that the hiring capacity in the city may be limited, posing a structural headwind for businesses looking to expand. The negative growth rate suggests that the labor pool is shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is increasing by 83.04% year-over-year, indicating a rapidly expanding housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating workforce in the future. The strong growth in building permits is a positive sign for the city's housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.8%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market indicates a slower, more buyer-friendly market.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The strong office economy suggests a high concentration of specialized roles.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a dynamic and expanding economy with strong wage growth and a rapidly growing housing supply. However, the city's tight labor market and moderate affordability may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and attract talent without wage premiums, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering a location in this city. Overall, the city's strengths make it an attractive location for businesses in the knowledge economy, but its weaknesses require careful consideration.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B

AVERAGE

52.3th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		62
25% weight		
Unemployment		80
20% weight		
Wage Growth		82
15% weight		
Cost of Living		18
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		10
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Days on Market		6
5% weight		
Office Economy		60
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -11.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, -7.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, at 3.60% and 62nd percentile, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by its above-average employment growth of 0.28% and weekly hours deviation of 0.421%, indicating genuine demand expansion. With a wage growth rate of 6.51%, this city also exhibits strong labor cost pressures.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.28% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.421%, signaling genuine demand expansion as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.11, at the 62nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 3.60%, ranking at the 80th percentile, which means the market is tight with low unemployment. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages, making it essential to offer competitive compensation packages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 6.51%, placing it at the 82nd percentile, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth implies that employer labor costs are rising quickly, while workers enjoy increased purchasing power. However, for businesses, this means a higher cost environment that needs to be factored into operational budgets and strategic planning.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 18th, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$649/sqft to \$50.06/hr, or 12.96. Although the PSF is falling by 4.1% YoY, the city remains less affordable, which can hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living. This suggests that businesses may need to adjust their compensation strategies to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -1.81% year-over-year, ranking at the 10th percentile, which means the labor force supply is shrinking. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is

decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. This trend can exacerbate the challenges posed by low unemployment and high wage growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is -11.22%, indicating that housing supply is tightening rather than expanding. This decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could further exacerbate affordability issues and make it more difficult for the workforce to find accommodation, ultimately affecting the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 7.5%, placing it at the 6th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it competitive and challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The rapid turnover in the housing market underscores the need for businesses to consider the housing situation in their relocation and talent attraction strategies.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has an office economy percentile rank of 60th, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different skill sets and infrastructures.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment and a deep professional talent pool, but it also presents significant challenges, including a tight labor market, high and rising labor costs, and a highly competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living and tightening housing supply, which can hinder talent attraction and retention without appropriate strategic adjustments.

Cleveland

Cleveland

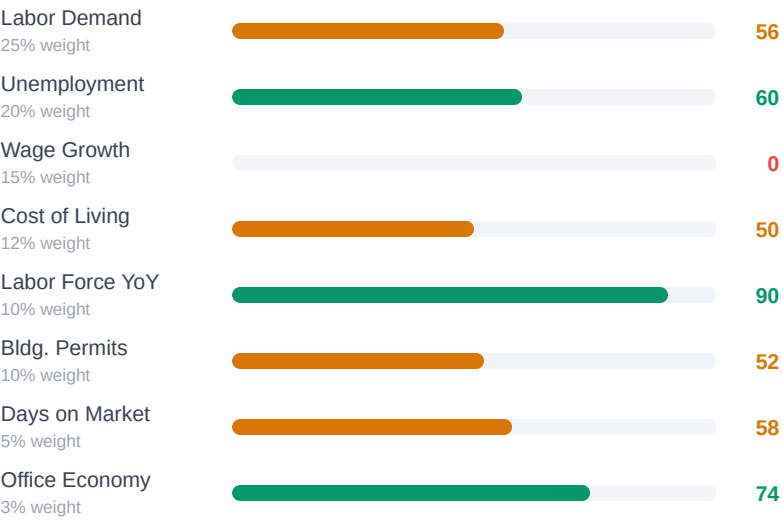
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AVERAGE

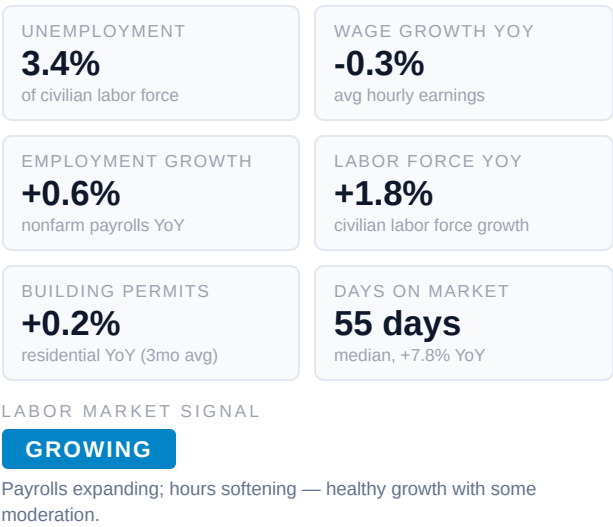
51.3th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its near-median labor demand and above-average unemployment rate. The city's economic character is defined by a labor demand composite score of 4.71, which is near the median, and a labor force growth rate of +1.80% YoY, placing it in the top tier. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively stable job market and an expanding workforce.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.388% below trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below the city's own trend, suggesting some degree of labor market stability rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand is not strongly indicative of either significant growth or contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This rate implies that it may be somewhat easier for businesses to hire in this city compared to others with tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent, albeit less intense than in cities with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Cleveland experiences a -0.33% year-over-year change in average hourly earnings, placing it in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to control expenses. However, it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially less consumer spending power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$143/sqft to \$33.79/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.23, Cleveland ranks near the median (50th percentile) in terms of affordability. This suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The PSF has increased by 13.5% YoY, which may indicate a future increase in the cost of living. This moderate affordability means that businesses may not necessarily need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but the rising PSF could change this dynamic.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% YoY, placing it in the top tier. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms

of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

Cleveland sees a +0.17% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median. This slight increase suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the modest growth rate may not be sufficient to meet future demand, potentially leading to affordability challenges.

Days on Market

Homes in Cleveland currently sit on the market for a median of 55 days, with a +7.8% YoY increase, placing it near the median. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less competitive, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find homes. The rising days on market suggest a healthy normalization of the housing market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Cleveland has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking at the 74th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require specialized knowledge-economy roles. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a relatively stable labor market with an expanding workforce, which can be beneficial for hiring and growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which, while controlling labor costs, may also indicate weaker consumer demand and less attractive conditions for talent relocation. Businesses should weigh these factors carefully when considering Cleveland as a location.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

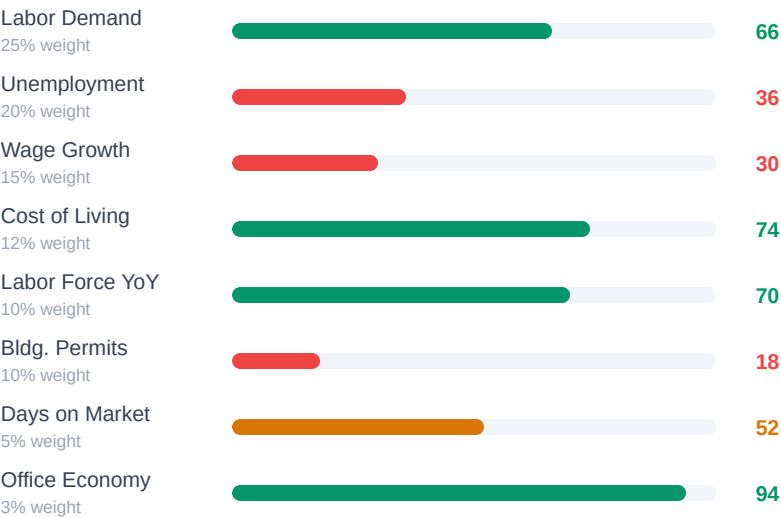
B

AVERAGE

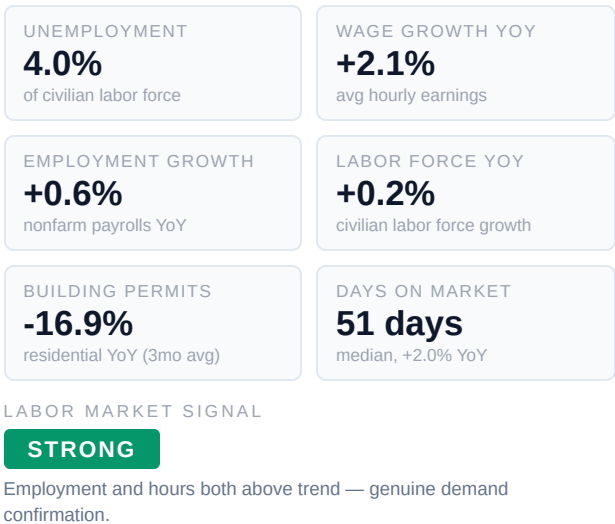
51.2th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 51.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.21, combining a 0.57% employment growth rate and a 0.116% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and hourly earnings of \$36.94, resulting in a ratio of 5.47, ranks in the 74th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.57% and weekly hours deviation of 0.116% above trend indicate genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.21, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.00%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 2.07%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as rapidly as in areas with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a cost of living ranking in the 74th percentile, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and hourly earnings of \$36.94, resulting in a ratio of 5.47. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordability of the city can be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.19% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a relatively healthy hiring environment, with a increasing pool of

potential workers. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, and businesses may still face some challenges in finding the right talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 16.94% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline suggests that the city may face future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for housing and upward pressure on prices.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%, ranking in the 52nd percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, where homes are selling at a moderate pace. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, providing a relatively stable environment for finding a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.18, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized talent. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of genuine labor demand expansion, relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting some of the city's advantages.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B

AVERAGE

50.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		38
25% weight		
Unemployment		44
20% weight		
Wage Growth		92
15% weight		
Cost of Living		24
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		38
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		84
10% weight		
Days on Market		28
5% weight		
Office Economy		70
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +20.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 82 days median, -1.2% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its 7.46% year-over-year wage growth and 20.81% increase in building permits, indicating a mix of rising labor costs and expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy, but also with challenges in labor demand and cost of living.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.30% year-over-year, combined with a -0.119% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks below average, at the 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.60%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but it also does not indicate a large pool of readily available workers. This balance may lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.46%, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests rising labor costs for employers, which could be a challenge for businesses looking to minimize expenses. However, it also means good news for worker purchasing power, as higher wages can lead to increased consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks below average, at the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$357/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.29/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.41. The city's PSF is decreasing by 1.1% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. However, the overall cost of living remains relatively high, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums, as the high cost of housing relative to wages could deter some potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the labor pool is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the area. Businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient talent to support their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has increased by 20.81% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This significant increase in building permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that future housing supply will be more ample, potentially improving affordability and making it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 82 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.2%, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The decreasing days on market further suggests a hot market that may favor sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking above average, at the 70th percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce, particularly in professional services, but may be less ideal for industries that require large amounts of industrial or logistics space.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and contracting labor force supply, which could pose challenges in attracting and retaining talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

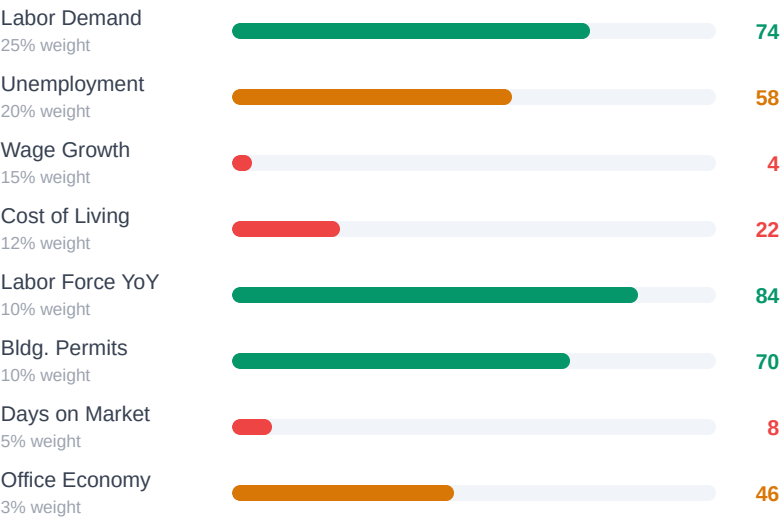
B

AVERAGE

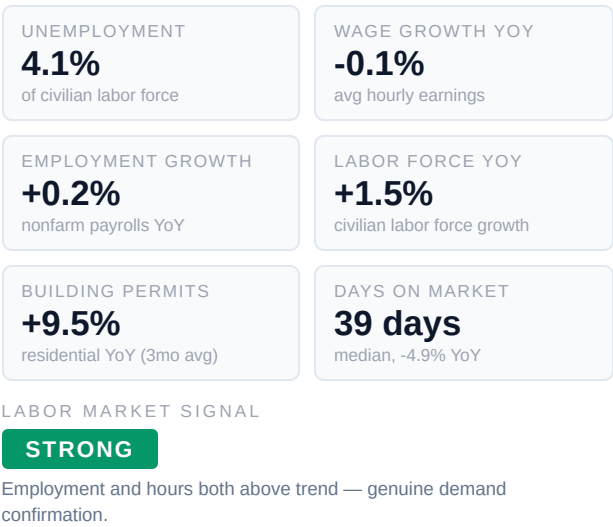
50.6th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which stand at 74th and 84th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand is characterized by a 0.19% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.039% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. These numbers suggest a city with genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.19% and weekly hours deviation of 1.039% above trend signal a genuine demand expansion in the city, indicating that jobs are being added and workers are putting in more hours. This combination suggests a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.61, ranking at the 74th percentile, further reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington stands at 4.10%, placing it near the median at the 58th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack, suggesting that businesses may face moderate challenges in hiring but without extreme wage pressure. The market's balance means that hiring can be managed with strategic planning.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is -0.06%, ranking at the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow pace suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not strengthening. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but for workers, it translates to weak bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$232/sqft to \$32.67/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and a percentile rank of 22, the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF has decreased by 0.4% year-over-year, which slightly mitigates the expense but does not significantly alter the city's affordability profile. This expense profile may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability does not serve as a natural attractor.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.49% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is 9.53%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. The growth in building permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.9%. This decrease indicates a competitive market that is slightly cooling, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find homes. However, the market remains relatively fast-moving, which could still pose challenges for some buyers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, combined with its growth trend, places the city at the 46th percentile. This ranking suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, though it may not be as robust as in other metros. The city is less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, which are significant advantages for recruitment and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and stagnant wage growth, which may necessitate offering wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, potentially increasing labor costs.

Columbus

Columbus

B

AVERAGE

50.0th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		48
Unemployment 20% weight		96
Wage Growth 15% weight		44
Cost of Living 12% weight		37
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		16
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		82
Office Economy 3% weight		24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 2.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +3.6%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.2%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -1.5%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -20.4%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +8.3% YoY 39 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a 50.0th percentile composite score, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.70% and a labor demand composite score of 4.60, which is near the median at the 48th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market but moderate job growth. The combination of a low unemployment rate and near-median labor demand score defines Columbus's current economic character, with specific numbers indicating a challenging hiring environment.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.23% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.025% from its own trend, signaling a moderate expansion of jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend. This combination suggests genuine demand expansion, albeit at a slow pace. The labor demand composite score of 4.60, at the 48th percentile, reinforces this interpretation, indicating a city with job growth but not excessively strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.70%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which means the market is extremely tight. This low unemployment rate implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in Columbus, the tight labor market means that attracting and retaining talent will be difficult and potentially costly.

Wage Growth

Columbus experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.58%, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers enjoy some increase in purchasing power. The implication is that businesses should expect labor costs to increase, but the pace of growth is manageable.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$208/sqft to \$34.02/hr, Columbus ranks at the 37th percentile, indicating that the city is less affordable than many of its peers. This relatively low affordability score means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the cost of living is higher than in many other cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.50% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it even more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The implication is that businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development.

Building Permits

Columbus has seen a -20.36% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The signal is clear: future workforce attraction and retention may be at risk due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus currently sit on the market for 39 days, with an 8.3% year-over-year increase, placing it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to Columbus may find it easier to find a home, as the market is less competitive. However, this also indicates a normalization of the housing market, which could be a positive sign for long-term stability.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks below average at the 24th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a tight labor market with moderate job growth and a relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could significantly impact the ability to attract and retain talent. Businesses considering Columbus must carefully weigh these factors and potentially develop strategies to mitigate the challenges posed by the city's economic character.

Fresno

Fresno

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.9th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		78
Unemployment 20% weight		0
Wage Growth 15% weight		66
Cost of Living 12% weight		53
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		66
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		38
Days on Market 5% weight		54
Office Economy 3% weight		34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 7.4%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +5.2%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +2.0%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth 0.0%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -6.9%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +5.8% YoY 55 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 0th percentile, with a rate of 7.40%. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.04% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are deviating from trend by -1.744%, still resulting in a labor demand composite score in the 78th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong labor market. The labor demand is robust, suggesting that businesses can find workers, but may face competition for talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.40%, which is in the bottom tier at 0th percentile, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that the market is not tight, and businesses may find it easier to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 5.16% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth is moderate to fast, suggesting that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect to benefit from a more affluent local workforce.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score in the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$263/sqft to \$33.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.86. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap compared to its peers. The stable year-over-year change in PSF (+0.0% YoY) suggests that affordability is not improving or deteriorating significantly. As a result, businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but may still face some challenges in retaining workers due to the relatively average cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of 0.00% year-over-year, which is ranked in the 66th percentile, indicating a stable labor supply. This means that the workforce is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, suggesting that businesses may not face significant challenges in hiring, but also may not benefit from a rapidly growing talent pool. The implication is that hiring capacity is unlikely to be severely constrained, but businesses should still plan carefully to attract and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year, which is ranked in the 38th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.8%, resulting in a percentile rank of 54. This means that the market is slowing down slightly, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and businesses may need to consider the potential impact of housing market conditions on their ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

Fresno has an office economy score in the 34th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses that require a more general workforce, such as logistics or manufacturing companies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack, as well as a relatively average cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Fresno as a potential location for their business.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

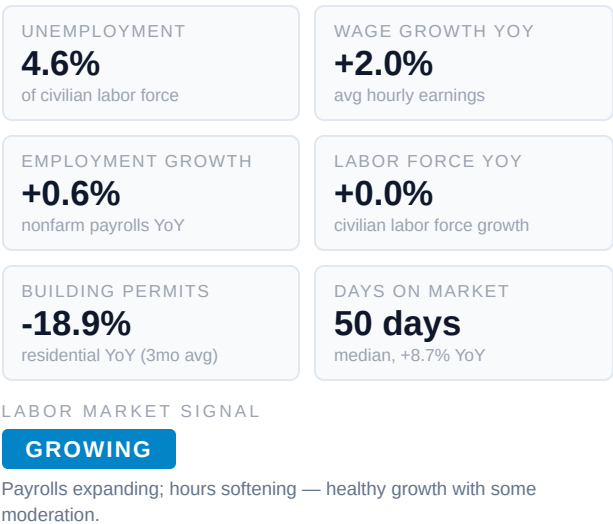
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.0th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 60th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 90th percentile. Specifically, the cost of living is characterized by a PSF of \$172/sqft, which has decreased by 2.3% YoY, combined with an average hourly wage of \$36.50, resulting in a ratio of 4.71.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 0.61% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.091%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new jobs without overburdening existing workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.06 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.60%, which is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 2.01%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not rapidly. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 90, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers. The decreasing PSF of \$172/sqft (-2.3% YoY) compared to the average hourly wage of \$36.50/hr makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.03% YoY, indicating a very slow expansion of the workforce supply. While this growth is positive, its slow pace may pose a structural headwind for hiring, particularly if businesses are looking to rapidly expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -18.95%, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in permits may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness for both businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with an 8.7% YoY increase. This indicates a slowing market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find suitable housing. However, this trend also suggests a normalization of the market rather than a rapid expansion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranked at the 80th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This makes the city an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands offers businesses an attractive combination of affordable living costs and a deep professional talent pool, making it suitable for knowledge-economy sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future housing affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

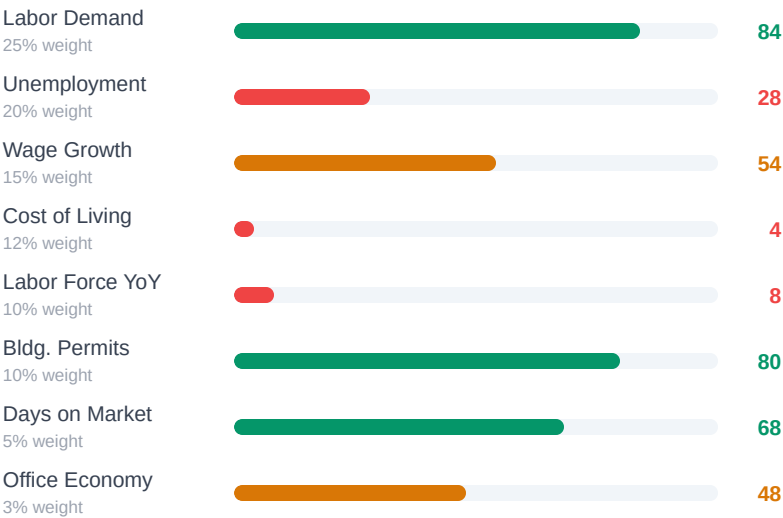
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

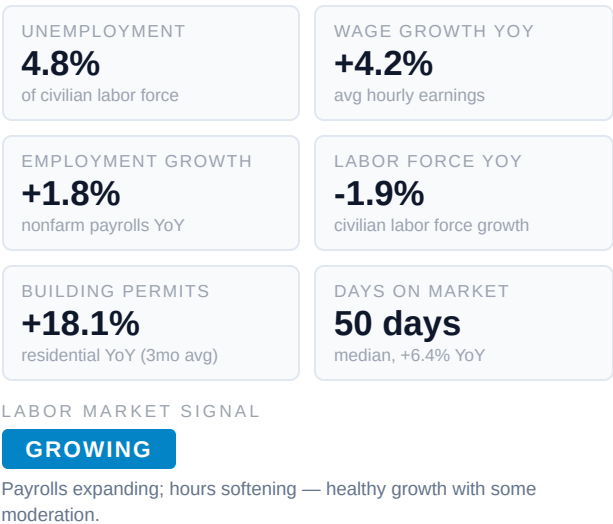
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.8th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 48.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, and its extremely high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.627% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.83% employment growth rate and a -0.627% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite job growth. This indicates that the labor market is experiencing real growth rather than just a redistribution of work among fewer workers. The top-tier labor demand composite score of 6.23 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 4.80%, which ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This means there is some slack in the market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with very low unemployment rates. However, the market is not so loose that it would lead to significantly weaker consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.18%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising but not at an alarming pace. At the same time, it supports worker purchasing power, contributing to a stable consumer demand environment.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is extremely expensive, with a cost of living percentile rank of 4, indicating it is one of the least affordable cities. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$662/sqft vs \$41.42/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98. Although the PSF is falling by 2.5% year-over-year, the city remains very costly. This high cost of living poses a significant challenge for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the expensive living conditions.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking at the 8th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in this area may face challenges in finding sufficient labor.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing an 18.09% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking at the 80th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help mitigate some of the pressure on housing costs and availability.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is moderate, with a composite score ranking at the 48th percentile. This suggests a decent but not exceptionally deep talent pool for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations. The city is somewhat suited for these types of businesses but may not offer the same level of specialized talent as cities with a higher concentration of professional and office jobs.

In conclusion, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a strong labor demand environment, which is a significant advantage for businesses looking to expand or establish operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which poses challenges for talent attraction and may require wage premiums to compensate for the expensive living conditions.

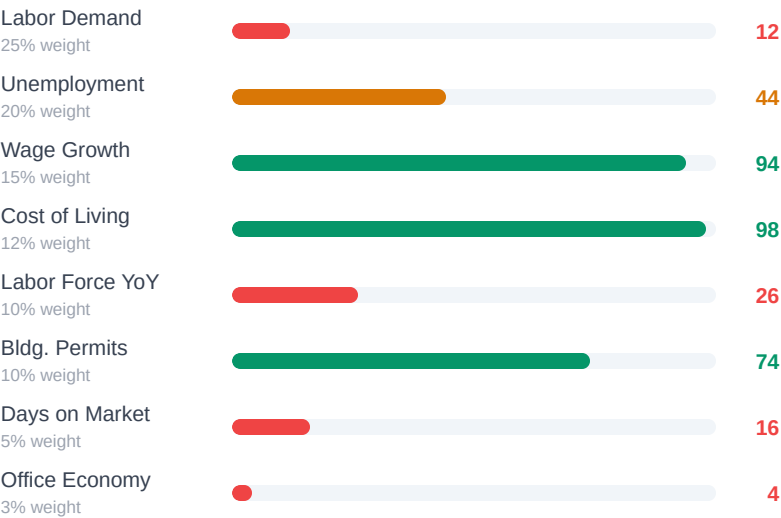
Memphis

Memphis

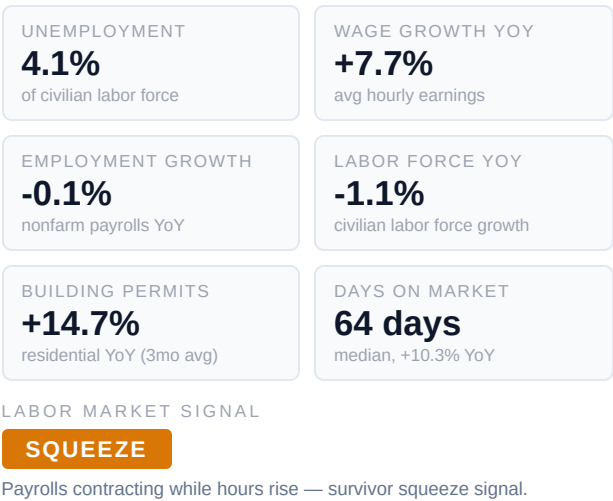
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.6th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 48.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its unique combination of strong wage growth and an affordable cost of living, with a cost of living ratio of \$155/sqft vs \$33.25/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. The city's economic character is also defined by its labor demand, which is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile due to a -0.11% employment growth rate and a +1.092% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. These metrics signal a complex economic environment that warrants closer examination.

Labor Demand

Memphis has a labor demand composite score of 3.05, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, due to a -0.11% employment growth rate and a +1.092% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing a decline in employment growth despite an increase in weekly hours worked. This suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, there is still some competition for workers, and wages may be subject to moderate pressure.

Wage Growth

Memphis is experiencing a strong wage growth of +7.68% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$155/sqft vs \$33.25/hr and a percentile rank of 98th, Memphis is an extremely affordable city relative to its peers. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The city's affordability is a major talent attraction advantage, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -1.15% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for this trend.

Building Permits

Memphis is experiencing a +14.68% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and growing pool of potential employees in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Memphis is 64 days, with a +10.3% year-over-year increase, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For a worker relocating to Memphis, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 0.48, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, Memphis may be more attractive to industries with different talent requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, an affordable cost of living, and an expanding housing supply. However, the city's labor demand contraction, declining labor force supply, and limited professional talent pool pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Memphis as a potential business location.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.4th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		76
Unemployment 20% weight		50
Wage Growth 15% weight		8
Cost of Living 12% weight		61
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		42
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		36
Days on Market 5% weight		30
Office Economy 3% weight		52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -8.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 54 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.63 ranking it in the 76th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +0.37% ranking it in the 8th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market but limited upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.63% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.445%, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.63 reinforces this interpretation, ranking the city in the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 3.20%, ranking it in the 50th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that the market is neither extremely tight nor extremely loose, with some availability of workers for hire. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not overly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Birmingham is +0.37%, ranking it in the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies limited bargaining power for workers and potentially weak purchasing power. As a result, businesses may face a relatively flat cost environment, but workers may not have strong incentives to relocate to the city.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living percentile rank of 61, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.80/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.88. The city's PSF is falling by -1.8% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage could attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -0.77% year-over-year, ranking it in the 42nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates, potentially limiting their growth prospects in the city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Birmingham is -8.10%, ranking it in the 36th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. This trend may pose a risk to businesses relying on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This relatively fast market implies that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. However, the stable year-over-year direction suggests that the market is not becoming significantly more competitive.

Office Economy

Birmingham's office economy has a percentile rank of 52, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. The city's share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 2.76, suggesting a moderate presence of specialized roles. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a strong labor market with above-average demand, but its stagnant wage growth and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses. The city's affordability advantage and moderate unemployment rate make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses, but decision-makers should carefully consider the potential challenges in finding and accommodating skilled workers. Overall, Birmingham's economic character is complex, and businesses must weigh the benefits and drawbacks carefully when considering a location decision.

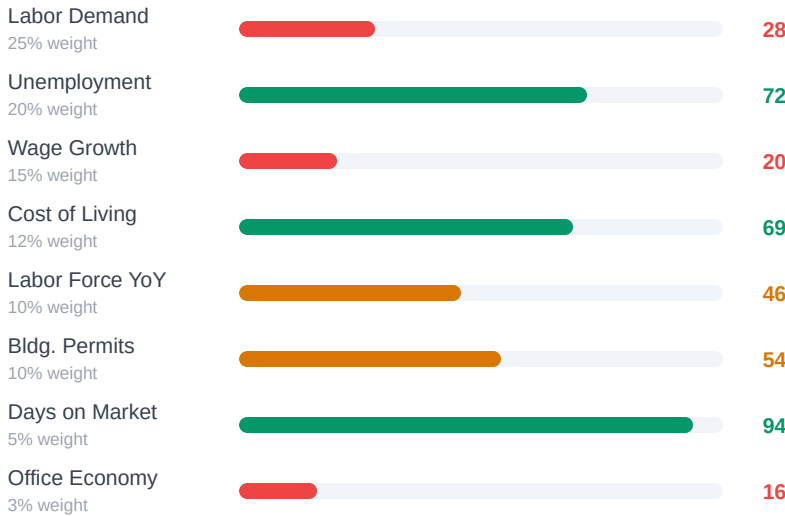
St. Louis

St. Louis

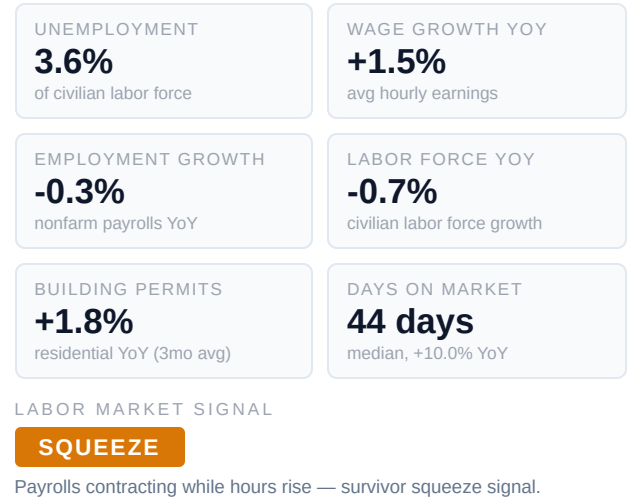
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.9th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.50 ranking it in the 28th percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks it in the 72nd percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively tight labor market but sluggish job growth.

Labor Demand

St. Louis has an employment growth rate of -0.27% and a weekly hours deviation of +0.423% from its own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.50 confirms this, ranking the city in the 28th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, which is relatively low and ranks the city in the 72nd percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.53%, which is below average and ranks the city in the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also indicates weaker bargaining power.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$164/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.16/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.41. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF (-1.2% YoY) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes St. Louis an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is shrinking at a rate of -0.72% year-over-year, ranking the city near the median in the 46th percentile. This contraction in labor supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +1.84% year-over-year, ranking the city near the median in the 54th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, providing a more favorable environment for businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking the city in the top tier with a 94th percentile score. This slower market indicates that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 16th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market, but its sluggish job growth and shrinking labor force pose significant challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor supply, which may hinder hiring capacity and require companies to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

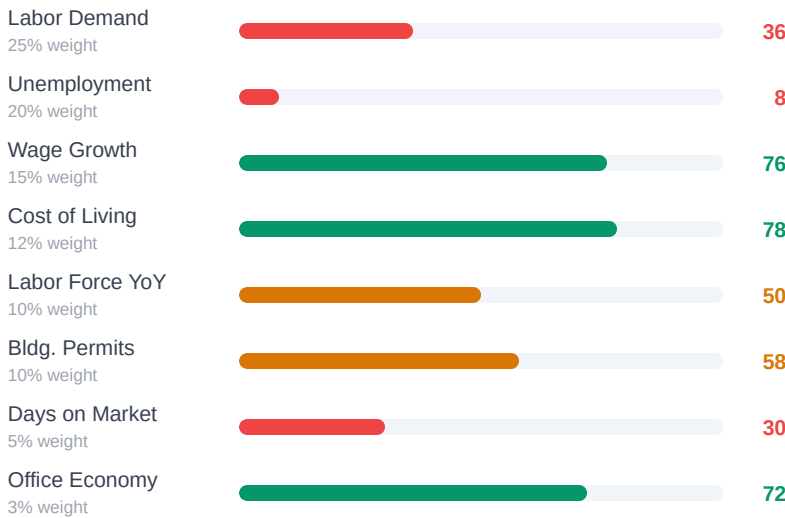
Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

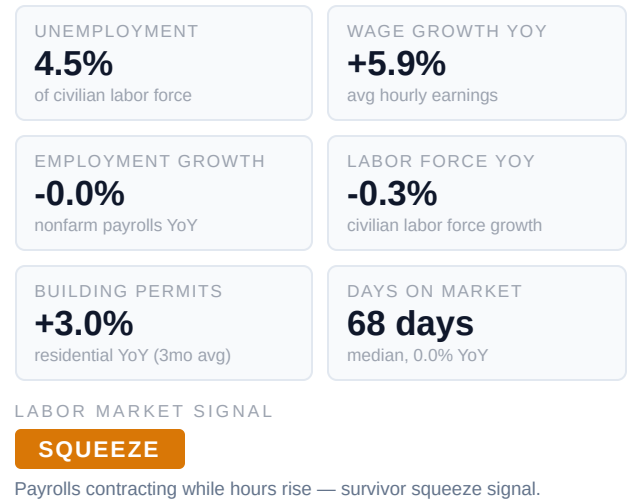
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.78 ranking it in the 36th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 5.90% year-over-year, ranking it in the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -0.03% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.480%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.78 ranks in the 36th percentile, indicating below-average labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.50%, ranking it in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.90%, ranking it in the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score ranking it in the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$238/sqft to \$37.05/hr, or 6.42. The fact that PSF is falling by -4.4% year-over-year contributes to its high affordability score. This makes the city more attractive for talent attraction without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of -0.30% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is increasing by 3.02% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has an office economy score ranking it in the 72nd percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction. However, the city's below-average labor demand and slightly contracting labor pool pose a risk to hiring capacity, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location.

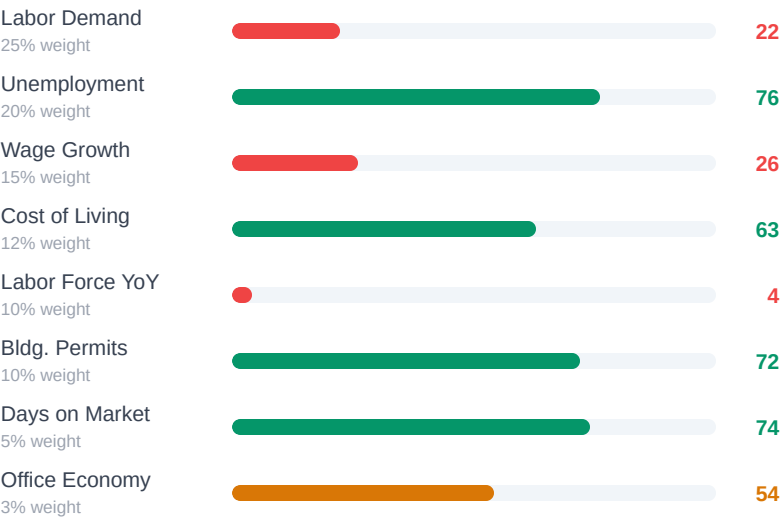
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

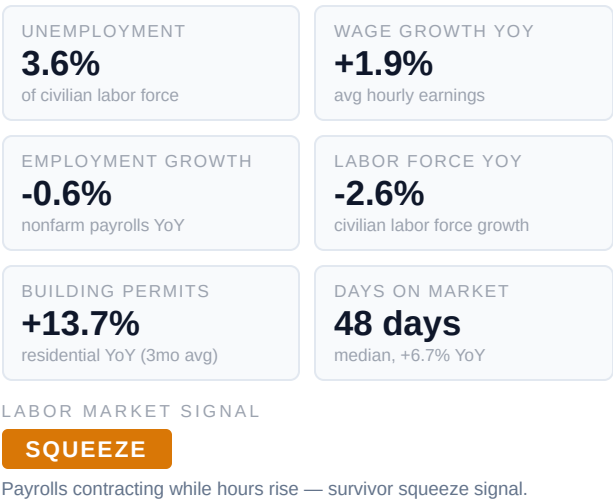
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.1th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.35 ranking it at the 22nd percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.60% ranking it at the 76th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.57% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.147% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing significantly despite job losses. This scenario may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.60%, ranking it at the 76th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure and hiring challenges. With a tight market, employers may need to offer higher wages or more attractive benefits to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.87%, ranking it at the 26th percentile, indicating moderate but not exceptional wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable pace, while worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. As a result, businesses may need to balance wage increases with productivity gains to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking it at the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of \$286/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.72. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF that is decreasing by 3.7% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.58% year-over-year, ranking it at the 4th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing workers or attract talent from other locations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by 13.68% year-over-year, ranking it at the 72nd percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and predictable housing market, reducing the risk of workforce disruption due to housing shortages.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%, ranking it at the 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a significant downturn in demand.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share ranking it at the 54th percentile, with a composite score of 2.80 out of 5. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. As a result, businesses in these sectors may find it easier to attract and retain specialized talent in this city.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market with moderate wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and business expansion. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their talent attraction and retention strategies when evaluating this location for relocation or expansion.

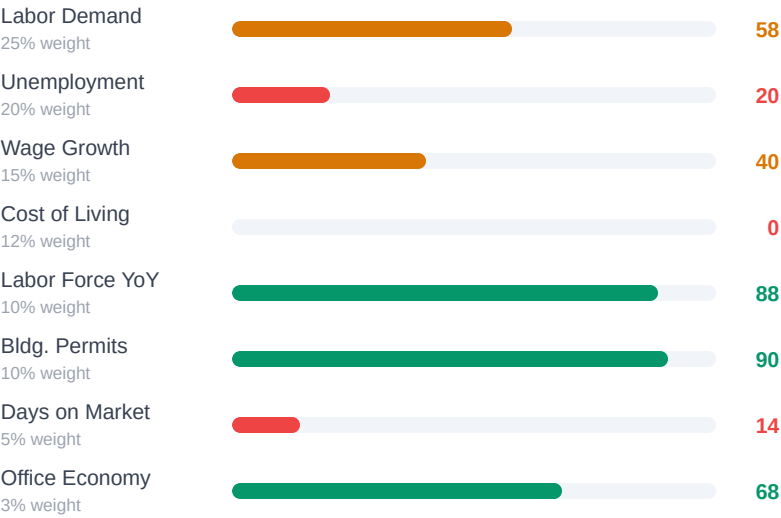
Providence

Providence-Warwick

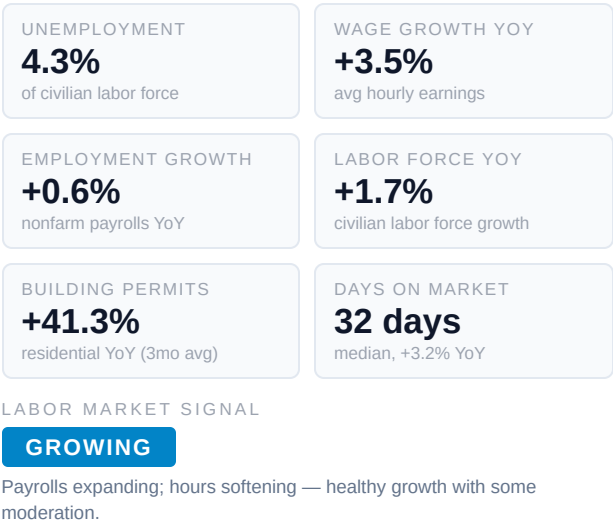
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of \$366/sqft to \$36.14/hr, ranking at the 0th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but significant challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to high costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.326% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.81, ranking at the 58th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, it may indicate some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The near-median ranking suggests a stable but not particularly robust labor demand environment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the tight labor conditions may lead to harder hiring and potential wage pressure, as the low unemployment rate suggests a competitive environment for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.52%, ranking at the 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract talent but also signals some upward pressure on labor costs.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living ratio of \$366/sqft to \$36.14/hr, with the PSF increasing by +8.9% YoY, ranking at the 0th percentile for affordability. This means the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The low affordability score is a major constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, ranking at the 88th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity in the area is strong, with a growing pool of potential employees, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Providence-Warwick is +41.33%, ranking at the 90th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This surge in building permits signals improving future affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce, which could help mitigate some of the current cost of living challenges.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.2%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 14th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market indicates a competitive environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy share of 3.14, ranking at the 68th percentile, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be less ideal for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses that rely on a different skill set.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, which are positive indicators for future growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which necessitates significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of locating in this area.

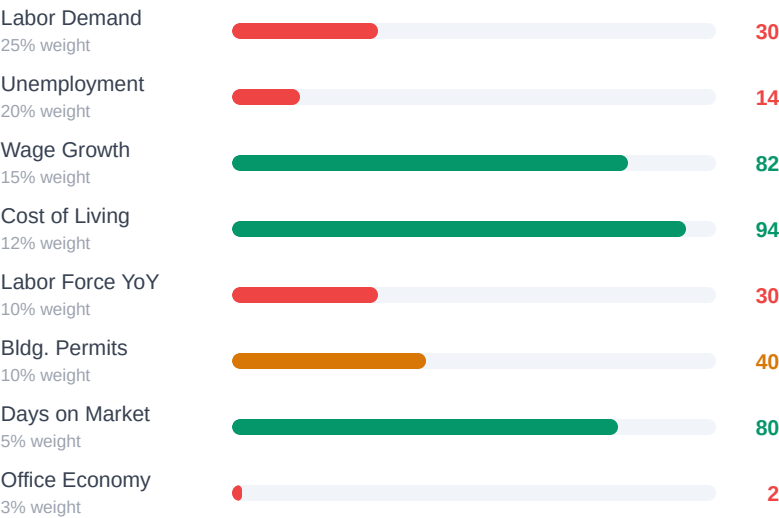
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

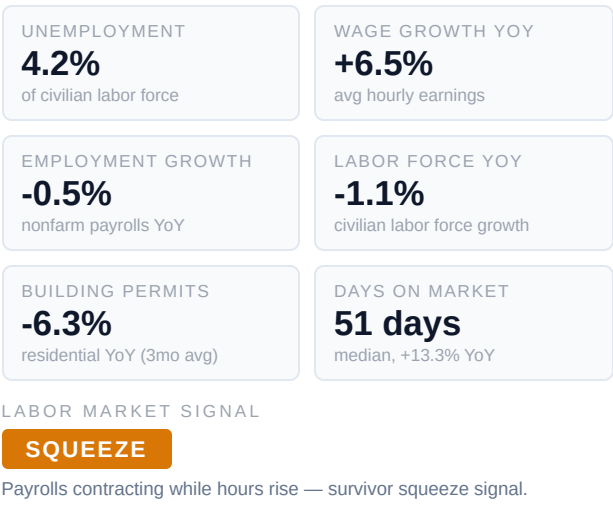
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.9th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 6.51% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.20%, which suggests a tight labor market. Additionally, the cost of living in Oklahoma City is relatively affordable, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.05, ranking it in the top tier at the 94th percentile.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.54% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.000%, indicating a labor demand composite score of 3.54, which ranks below average at the 30th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The lack of job growth and stagnant hours worked suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face significant competition for talent, leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer higher salaries or more attractive benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.51%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that employer labor costs are rising, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.05, ranking it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. The city's PSF is \$172/sqft, which has decreased by 0.6% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is contracting at a rate of -1.07% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth suggests that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Oklahoma City has decreased by 6.33% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Oklahoma City is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier for them to find a home.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, and more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a relatively slow housing market. However, the city's tight labor market, contracting labor force, and limited professional talent pool pose significant risks and constraints for businesses considering relocation or expansion in this city, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully weigh these factors when making their decision.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.6th percentile
Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		20
Unemployment 20% weight		50
Wage Growth 15% weight		56
Cost of Living 12% weight		65
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		56
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		26
Days on Market 5% weight		88
Office Economy 3% weight		26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.2%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.7%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.2%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -11.9%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +9.1% YoY 36 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics. The labor demand composite score of 3.28, combining a -0.73% employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with an unemployment rate of 4.30%, suggests significant challenges in the local job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.73% and weekly hours deviation of -0.398% from trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city is experiencing a period of job losses and reduced working hours. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, implying that businesses may face a surplus of labor rather than a shortage. The labor demand composite score of 3.28 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 20th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this market may find it easier to staff positions due to the available workforce, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The high unemployment rate suggests that the market is not tight, giving employers more flexibility in hiring and potentially reducing wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.24% is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is neither extremely fast nor stagnant. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.03, based on \$221/sqft (which is falling at a rate of -1.3% YoY) compared to \$36.68/hr, Baltimore-Columbia-Towson ranks above average in affordability at the 67th percentile. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 59th percentile. This minimal growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is barely expanding, suggesting a potential structural headwind for hiring in the future. However, the impact of this slow growth may be mitigated by the current surplus of labor.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -11.88%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline suggests that developer confidence may be waning, and the future housing supply may not keep pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%. This increase, ranking at the 78th percentile, suggests a slower market where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially easing the transition.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 1.66, ranks below average at the 26th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these areas. This suggests that Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is less suited for businesses requiring a strong presence of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, the Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, which could attract talent and support local consumer demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the challenging labor market, characterized by high unemployment and contracting labor demand, which may impact hiring strategies and local economic growth prospects.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.5th percentile
Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		82
25% weight		
Unemployment		30
20% weight		
Wage Growth		32
15% weight		
Cost of Living		47
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		22
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		8
10% weight		
Days on Market		46
5% weight		
Office Economy		76
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -29.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 64 days median, -1.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its below-average unemployment rate of 4.10%, which ranks at the 30th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, driven by a +0.96% employment growth rate and +0.193% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.96% and weekly hours deviation of +0.193% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, ranking at the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% is slightly above the national average, ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While the market is not extremely tight, it still presents some challenges for businesses trying to hire, as they may face competition for skilled workers. However, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros means that businesses may have a slightly easier time finding candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.55% is below average, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage pressure. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a dramatic pace. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain skilled workers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.22, based on \$269/sqft (which is decreasing by 1.8% YoY) and \$37.26/hr, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 47th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF value is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.31% year-over-year, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction presents a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates to fill open positions. The declining labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -29.08%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The low ranking in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 64 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.5%, ranking at the 46th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.30, ranking at the 76th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit its ability to support rapid business expansion and accommodate a growing workforce.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.1th percentile
Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		34
25% weight		
Unemployment		24
20% weight		
Wage Growth		42
15% weight		
Cost of Living		16
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		60
10% weight		
Days on Market		98
5% weight		
Office Economy		62
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.4% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +5.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, +19.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor force growth rate of +2.87% YoY and its cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.59, ranking it at the 16th percentile for affordability. The combination of a shrinking labor demand and high cost of living presents a unique challenge for businesses considering this location.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.44% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.650% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.68, which ranks at the 34th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job growth and a decrease in working hours. This scenario suggests that businesses may face a more competitive environment for talent, but also potentially weaker consumer demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking at the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.53%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the potential benefits of a more skilled and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living ranking at the 16th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.59, and PSF decreasing by -0.2% YoY. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may deter some workers from relocating to the area, potentially limiting the pool of available talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential

workers, making it easier to hire and staff their operations. The expanding labor force also implies that the city is likely to have a more dynamic and diverse workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is increasing by +5.64% YoY, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city is likely to experience an increase in available housing, potentially improving affordability and making it easier for workers to relocate to the area. The expanding housing supply may also help to mitigate the high cost of living, making the city more attractive to businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 37 days, with a YoY increase of +19.4%, ranking at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The slower market may also give workers more negotiating power, potentially leading to better deals on housing.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 62nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, offering access to a highly skilled and specialized workforce. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a highly skilled workforce and a growing labor force, but also presents challenges such as a high cost of living and a tight labor market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to remain competitive.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

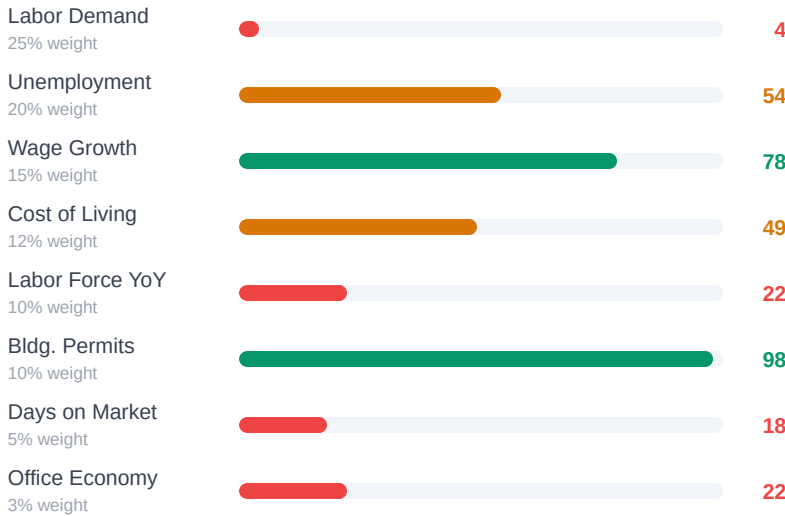
C+

POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.3%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+163.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days

median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year change in average hourly earnings of +6.14%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.397%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.70%, ranking near the median at 54th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not overly competitive hiring environment, with some wage pressure but not extreme.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is +6.14%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this area should be prepared for increasing labor costs but can also benefit from a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.27/hr, results in a ratio of 6.35, ranking near the median at 49th percentile. This suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not have a significant advantage in terms of cost of living but also do not face a significant disadvantage, making wage premiums less necessary to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of -1.31% year-over-year, ranking below average at 22nd percentile. This indicates a contracting labor force supply, which poses a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should be

aware of the potential challenges in finding and recruiting new talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +163.12%, ranking in the top tier at 98th percentile. This significant increase signals an expansion in housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. This is a positive indicator for future business operations and talent attraction, as it suggests that the area is becoming more accommodating for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.6%. This ranks in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, indicating a fast-paced market. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is competitive, making it challenging to find and secure housing quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in this metro area ranks below average at 22nd percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other metros, making it less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations. However, it may be more accommodating for industries with different workforce requirements.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, which can support workforce attraction and accommodation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force supply, which poses significant challenges for hiring and business expansion. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering this location for their operations.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		14
Unemployment 20% weight		84
Wage Growth 15% weight		18
Cost of Living 12% weight		20
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		60
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		64
Days on Market 5% weight		92
Office Economy 3% weight		16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.2%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +1.3%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.9%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.1%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +7.8%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +13.8% YoY 33 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at 14th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.20% ranking it in the top tier at 84th percentile. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -0.86% and weekly hours deviation of -0.000% signal a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.000% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate. The labor demand composite score of 3.10 is in the bottom tier at 14th percentile, further emphasizing the lack of genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.20%, ranking it in the top tier at 84th percentile. This tight labor market means that there is little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.33%, which is in the bottom tier at 18th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score in the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$230/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.31. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The 20th percentile rank suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, which is above average at 60th percentile. Although this growth rate is slightly negative, it indicates that the labor force supply is not contracting significantly. However, the slow growth rate may still pose a structural headwind for hiring in the long term.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +7.85% year-over-year, ranking it above average at 64th percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.8%, ranking it in the top tier at 92nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is relatively low, with a composite score ranking it in the bottom tier at 16th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in knowledge-economy sectors, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but this also means that businesses may face challenges in hiring and retaining talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's low labor demand and relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain workers. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Milwaukee-Waukesha as a potential location.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

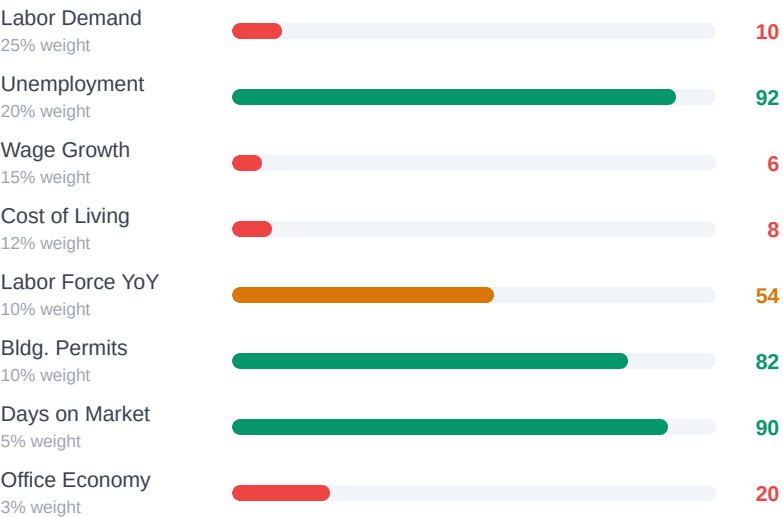
C+

POOR

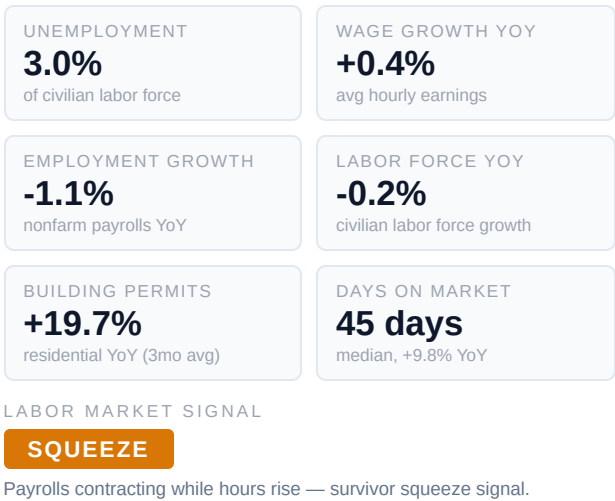
41.5th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 41.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.00% ranking it in the top tier. The combination of these two metrics, particularly the low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.398%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are not significantly above trend to indicate a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 2.42 ranks in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.00%, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 92. This tight labor market means that there is little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may be necessary to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.36%, ranking it in the bottom tier with a percentile score of 6. This stagnant wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier, with a percentile score of 8, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$167/sqft vs \$32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.09, and PSF is rising by 5.0% year-over-year. This means that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of -0.25% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a percentile score of 54. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, rather than expanding, which may create a structural

headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain top talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is increasing by 19.68% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 82. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is strong, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses looking to expand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.8%, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 90. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood ranks below average, with a percentile score of 20. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost environment, with a growing housing supply, but it also presents challenges, such as a tight labor market and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the low labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion and growth. As a result, businesses should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood as a potential location for relocation or expansion.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

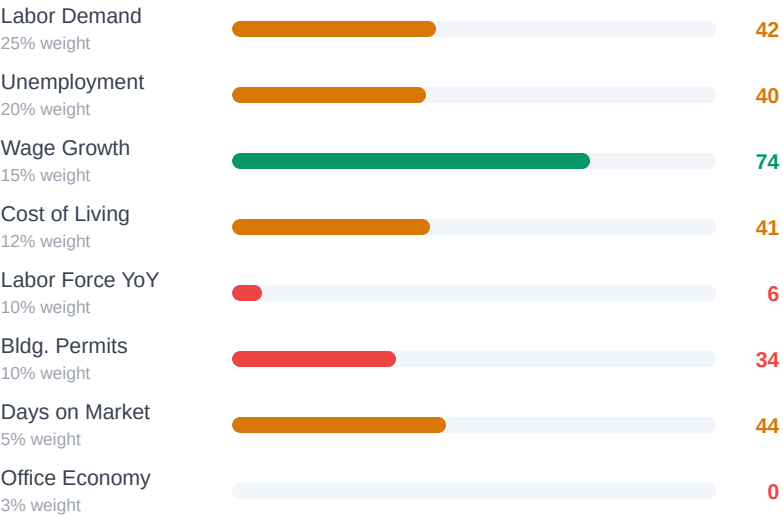
C+

POOR

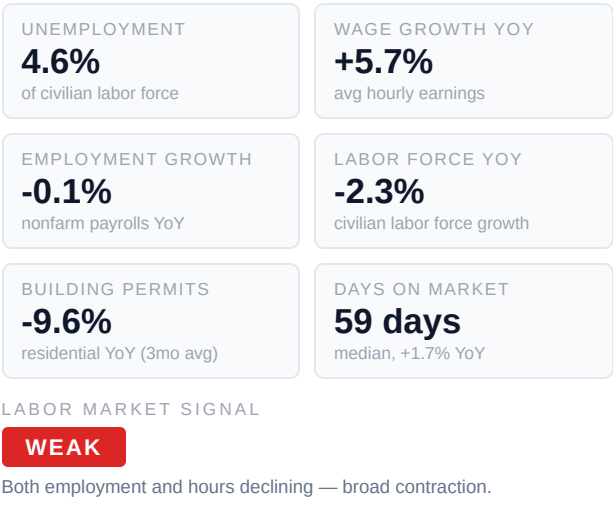
40.7th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand and wage growth, with a labor demand composite score of 4.13 and a wage growth rate of 5.74% year-over-year. The combination of near-median employment growth and above-average wage growth suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is -0.12% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.21% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 4.60%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This rate indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the availability of labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.74%, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking it near the median at the 41st percentile, with a PSF of \$335/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.50. The PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -2.31% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by -9.55% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of future housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less competitive over time. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is relatively accessible, but the trend suggests it may become more buyer-friendly.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 0th percentile in terms of office and professional worker share. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but it may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a mixed economic environment with above-average wage growth but faces significant challenges, including a contracting labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant structural headwind for hiring and expansion plans.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C+

POOR

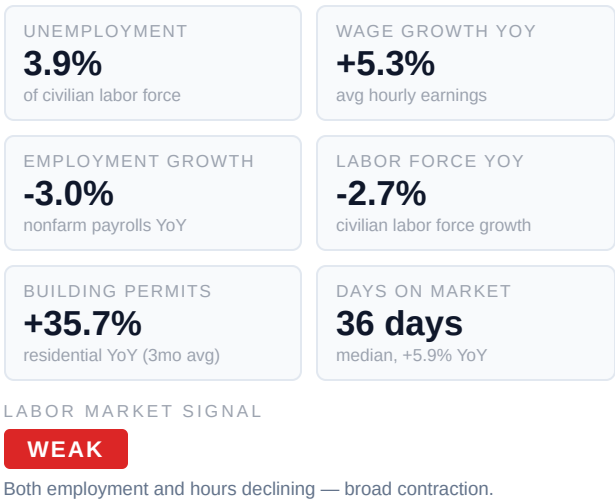
40.3th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.31%. The combination of a -2.95% employment growth rate and a -0.771% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.95% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also a potentially weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.90%, ranking it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor overly slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding qualified workers may be manageable, but wage pressure is not excessively high.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.31% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 68th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor expenses, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$308/sqft to \$44.92/hr, Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks above average at the 67th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -2.2% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -2.72% year-over-year, ranking it at the 2nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates, and may need to invest in training or recruitment programs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria are increasing by 35.66% year-over-year, ranking it at the 86th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.9%, ranking it at the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a professional and office worker share ranking it below average at the 32nd percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to balance labor costs and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and shrinking labor force supply, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

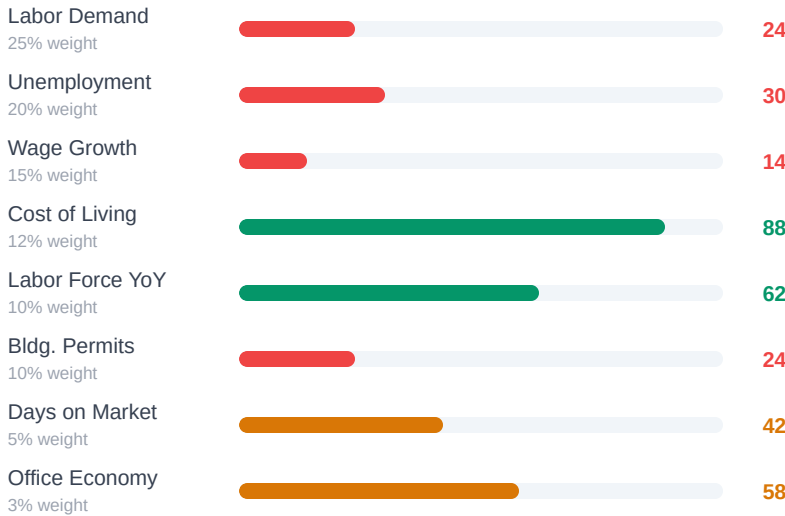
C

VERY POOR

37.1th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its below-average labor demand and slow wage growth, specifically a labor demand composite score of 3.36 and wage growth of +1.25% YoY. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate. With an employment growth rate of +0.40% and weekly hours deviation of -2.201%, the city's labor market is not showing strong signs of expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.40%, which is below average, and the weekly hours deviation is -2.201%, indicating that hours are running below trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather may be experiencing a slight contraction. The negative hours deviation suggests that the existing workforce may be absorbing the workload of eliminated roles, indicating a potential survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.10%, which is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, but not excessively so, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +1.25%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 14th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also means that workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power either.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living score that ranks in the 88th percentile, with a PSF of \$173/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.37. The fact that PSF is falling by -5.0% YoY relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of -0.11% YoY, which is slightly above average, ranking 62nd percentile. However, the negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is actually contracting, albeit slightly. This contraction

may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the available workforce is not expanding.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is decreasing by -12.00% YoY, which is below average. This decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 61 days, with a YoY decrease of -1.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, the near-median percentile rank of 42nd suggests that the market is not excessively competitive.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has an office economy score that ranks in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be ideal for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderately sized professional talent pool, but poses challenges in terms of labor demand and wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

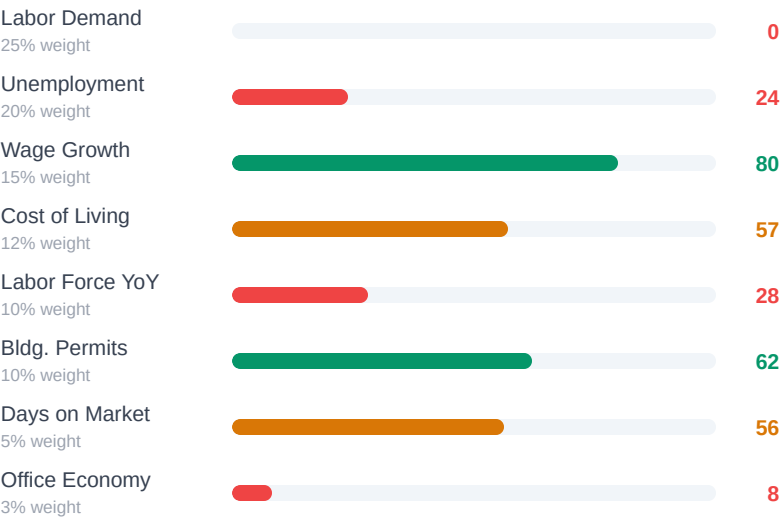
C

VERY POOR

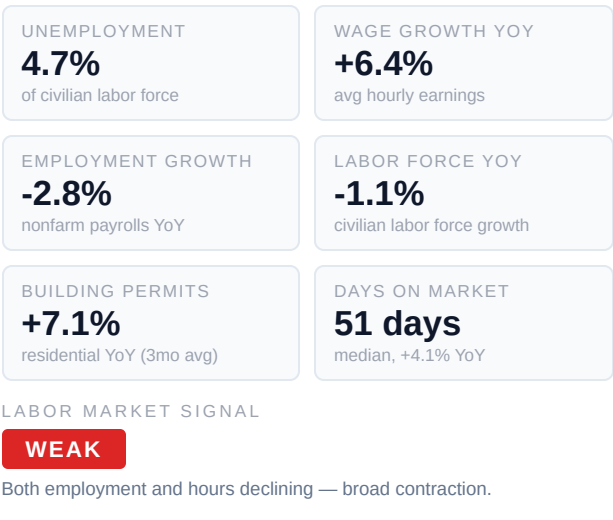
35.7th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, indicating a struggling job market. The city's economic character is most defined by its negative employment growth rate of -2.81% and high wage growth rate of +6.37%. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.81%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.489% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in job creation. The negative hours deviation suggests that the remaining workforce is not absorbing additional hours, further emphasizing the labor market's weakness.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.70%, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating a below-average but still relatively tight labor market. This level of unemployment suggests that while there is some slack in the market, hiring may still be challenging, and businesses may face upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +6.37%, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses will need to factor in higher labor costs when making location decisions.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$309/sqft, which is decreasing by -1.9% YoY, and an earnings ratio of \$41.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.37, ranking in the 57th percentile. This suggests that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, making it neither particularly attractive nor unattractive for talent without wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a positive sign, but the overall affordability is still average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -1.14% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by +7.12% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and the city's housing market may become more affordable in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.1%. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising DOM may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion, as the city's job market is still struggling.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has an office economy score ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses. While the city's high wage growth and expanding housing supply are positive signs, the struggling job market and shrinking labor pool pose significant risks for businesses looking to locate or expand in the area. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor market, which may limit the ability to attract and retain top talent.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

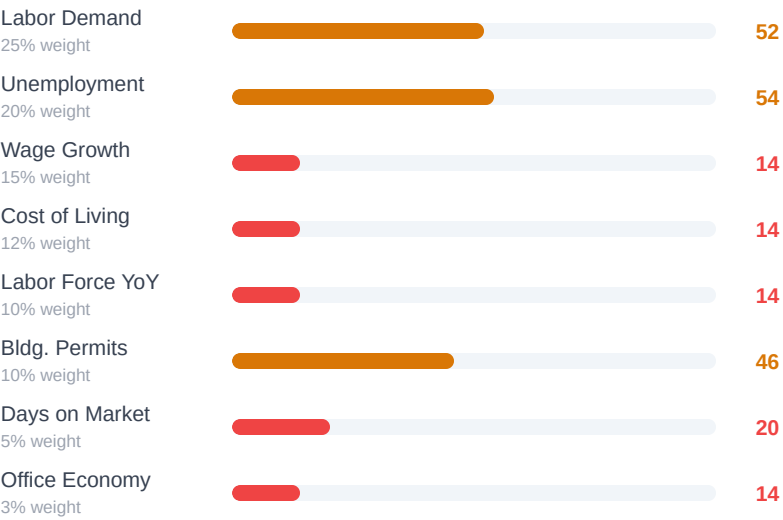
C

VERY POOR

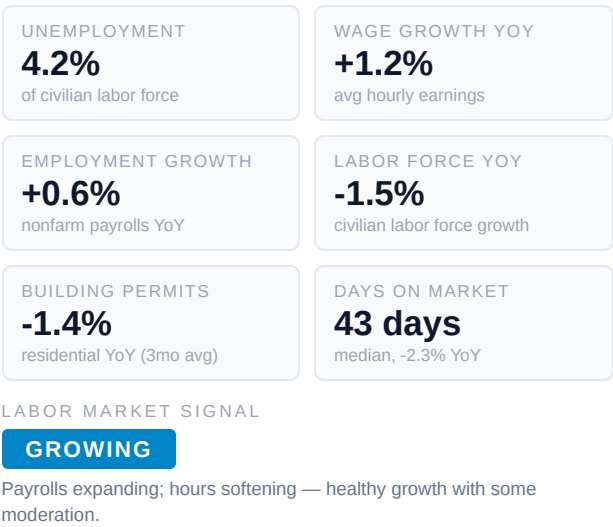
35.0th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking in the 35.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.64 and a cost of living ratio of 8.96. The city's current economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, at +1.25% year-over-year, and its bottom-tier labor force growth, at -1.52% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.456% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.64 is near the median, indicating a neutral labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.20%, which is near the median. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively higher unemployment rate means it may be easier to find candidates, but it also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.25%, which is in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local economic growth.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living ratio of 8.96, with a price per square foot of \$343 and average hourly earnings of \$38.27. The city's cost of living percentile rank is in the bottom tier, at 14th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living eats into workers' take-home pay.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses looking to expand in this city may face challenges in finding the talent they need, as the labor pool is not growing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is decreasing at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 43 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing trend in days on market suggests that the market may be normalizing, making it slightly more accessible for workers to find homes.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is relatively low, with a percentile rank of 14th. This indicates that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in these areas, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable labor market, but with significant challenges in terms of labor force growth and cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's stagnant wage growth and shrinking labor pool, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and drive up labor costs in the long run.

Richmond

Richmond

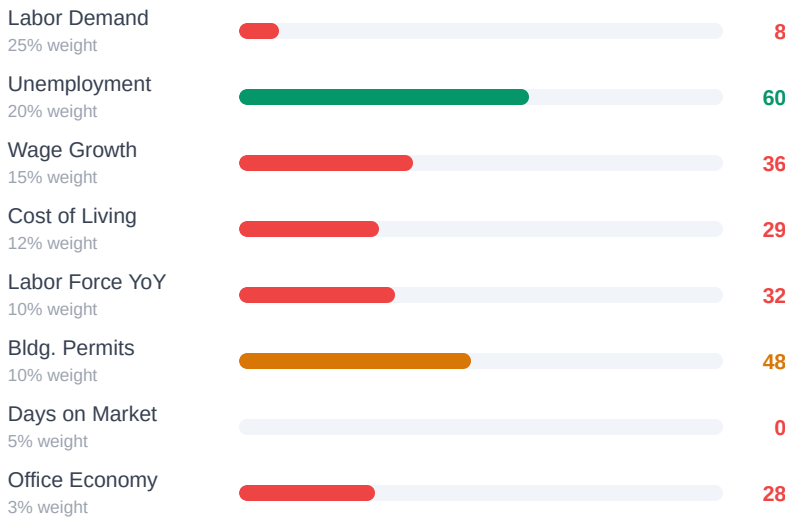
C-

CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days
median, -13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.27 ranking in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.50% ranking in the 60th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.87% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.807%. However, the combination of these metrics signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are being worked above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.50%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 60th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may be necessary to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Richmond is +3.00%, which is below average and ranks in the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. This could be a positive sign for businesses looking to balance labor costs with worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks in the 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$229/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.00/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.36. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.3% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.98% year-over-year, which ranks in the 32nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit top talent. This could be a significant constraint for businesses looking to expand in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is decreasing by -0.85% year-over-year, which ranks near the median. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk. This could lead to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers, making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Richmond is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.9%. This indicates a highly competitive market where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. This could be a significant concern for businesses looking to attract talent from outside the area.

Office Economy

Richmond has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force, expensive cost of living, and competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited labor force supply, which could hinder business expansion and growth plans.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

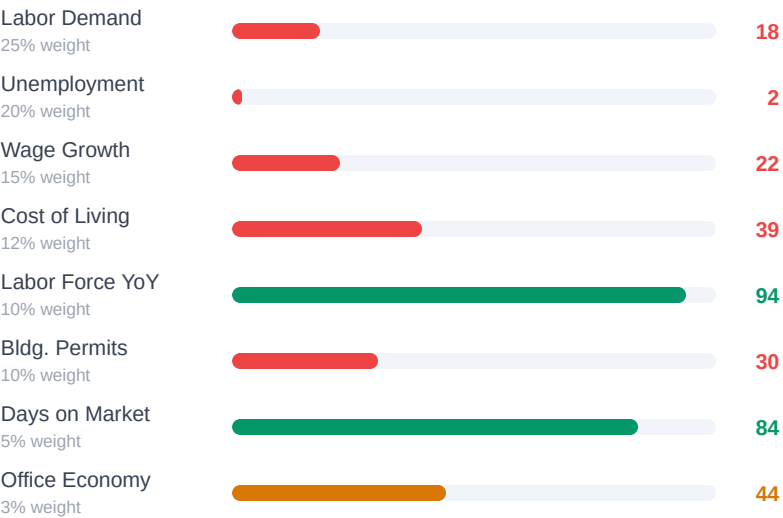
C-

CRITICAL

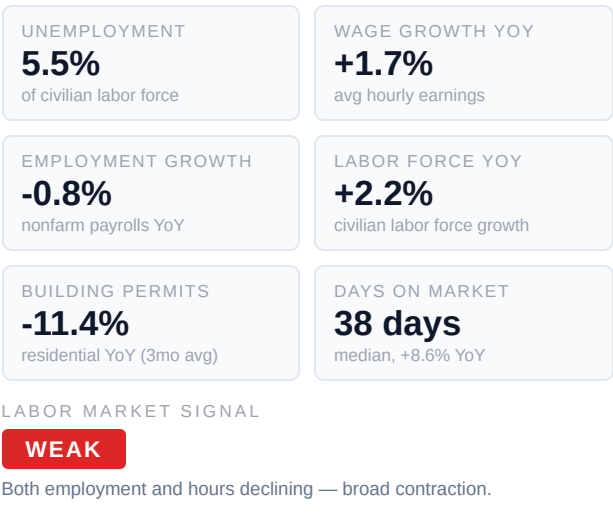
30.8th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.25 ranking it in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 5.50%, which is in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. These metrics signal significant challenges in the local job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.75% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.730% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This is a clear sign of a weakening job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.50%, which is in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. This high unemployment rate indicates that the market has significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.73%, ranking it below average at 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. This also means that worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a relatively slow rate.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it 39th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that the city's affordability is not improving or deteriorating significantly. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.21% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at 94th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -11.39% year-over-year, ranking it below average at 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.6%. This relatively slow pace of home sales, ranking in the top tier at 84th percentile, indicates a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the local real estate market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has an office economy score ranking it near the median at 44th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.48. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require specialized office workers, but less ideal for those seeking a highly concentrated tech or finance talent pool.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a growing labor force, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the city's low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which could limit the pool of skilled workers and impact local consumer demand. Despite these challenges, the city's relatively low cost of living and accessible housing market could make it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or relocate. However, decision-makers should carefully consider the local job market's weaknesses and their potential impact on business operations.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

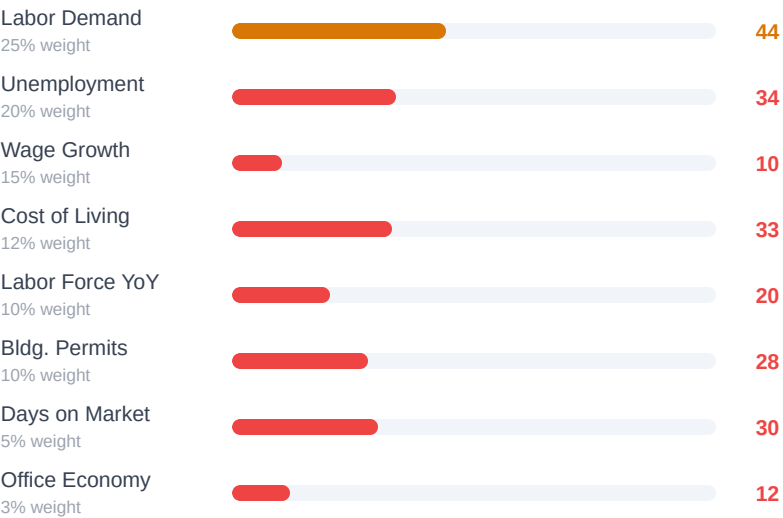
C-

CRITICAL

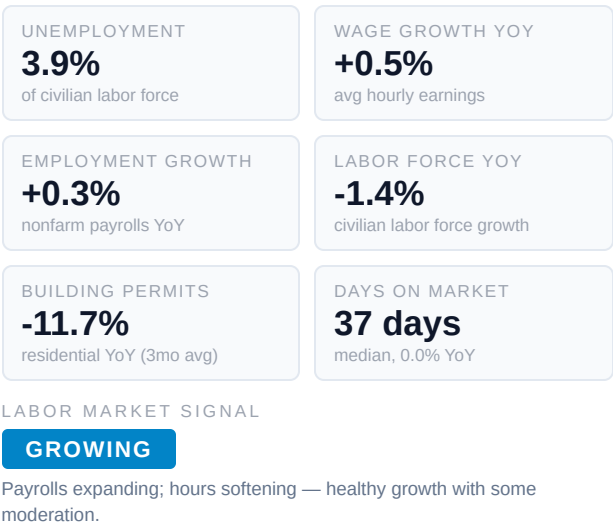
29.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low wage growth rate of +0.54% year-over-year and its below-average labor force growth rate of -1.38% year-over-year, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with limited labor market dynamism.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.495% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are below trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.18 ranks near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a lackluster labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.90%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.54%, ranking at the bottom tier of the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. This could have implications for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 33rd percentile, with a PSF of \$212/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.59/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.35. The PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, but the falling PSF could make it more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -1.38% year-over-year. This indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area. The implication is that businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need to grow.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -11.74%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for housing and upward pressure on prices.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 37 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This suggests a relatively stable housing market that is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible for relocating workers. The days on market rank below average at the 30th percentile, indicating a market that is slightly slower than peer cities.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks at the bottom tier of the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, which rely on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. Instead, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor market with some slack, but it also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth, a shrinking labor pool, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited labor market dynamism, which could hinder growth and expansion plans.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

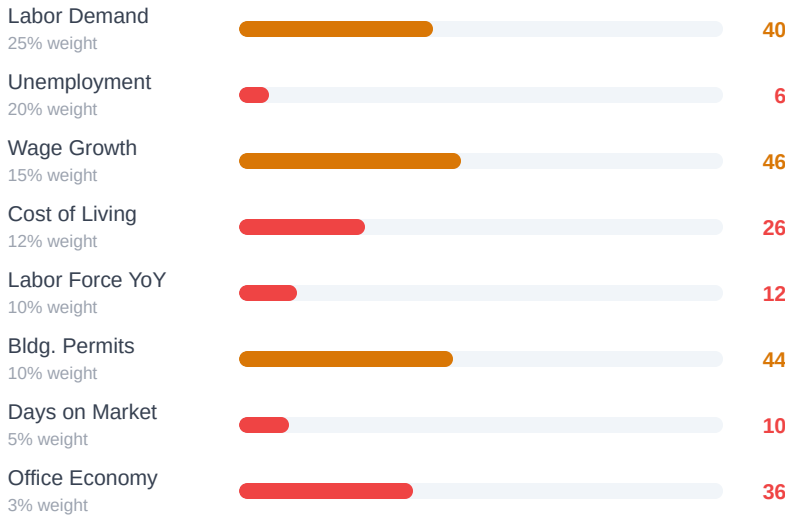
C-

CRITICAL

28.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-1.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 28.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 4.90% and its stagnant labor force growth of -1.66% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -0.01% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.300%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.99 ranks near the median at the 40th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking it at the 6th percentile, indicating a loose labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The low unemployment percentile rank suggests that the city's labor market is not tight.

Wage Growth

The YoY wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.59%, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth rate is not exceptionally high, which may limit the city's attractiveness to businesses looking for a highly competitive labor market.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score ranking it at the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$36.81/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.00. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.8% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -1.66% YoY, ranking it at the 12th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force growth rate limits the city's ability to support long-term business growth.

Building Permits

The YoY change in residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -1.45%, ranking it near the median at the 44th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation. The decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze ahead.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 33 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which may make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the slow market also suggests that demand for housing may be weakening.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks at the 36th percentile, with a composite score of 2.10. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as attractive to businesses requiring a highly specialized or industrial workforce.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively loose labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high unemployment rate, stagnant labor force growth, and tightening housing supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force growth rate, which limits its ability to support long-term business expansion and may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

D

EMERGENCY

21.1th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		26
25% weight		
Unemployment		36
20% weight		
Wage Growth		34
15% weight		
Cost of Living		6
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		0
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		12
10% weight		
Days on Market		2
5% weight		
Office Economy		10
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-6.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-21.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days

median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 21.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and cost of living metrics, which are both below average. The labor demand composite score is 3.43, placing it in the 26th percentile, while the cost of living ratio is 6.85, ranking in the 6th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging economic environment, with the labor demand score indicating a contraction and the cost of living being relatively expensive.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.62% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.775% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario points to a difficult hiring environment for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.40%, placing it in the 36th percentile, which indicates a degree of slack in the labor market. While this is not extremely high, it suggests that the market is not overly tight, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while there may be available workers, the overall economic conditions might not attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.67%, which is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising too quickly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly. For businesses, this could mean a relatively stable labor cost environment, but it might also indicate weaker bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ratio of 6.85, with PSF at \$224/sqft and hourly earnings at \$32.68/hr, and this ratio is increasing as PSF rises 6.2% year-over-year. Ranking in the 6th percentile for affordability, this city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging, as the high cost of living might deter potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -6.22% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This significant contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. For businesses looking to expand or establish operations, this could pose a significant challenge in finding and hiring the necessary talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -21.72%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it harder for the workforce to find accommodation, ultimately affecting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.3%, indicating a relatively fast-moving market. However, ranking in the 2nd percentile, this actually signifies a very competitive market where homes sell quickly, which could make it tough for relocating workers to find housing. This fast pace could be a challenge for businesses trying to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.80, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This suggests that Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The bottom line for a business considering Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is that while it may offer some advantages in terms of labor costs, the significant challenges in labor force growth, housing supply, and cost of living pose substantial risks. The single biggest constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the shrinking labor pool and its implications for hiring and talent attraction, which could outweigh any potential benefits of locating in this metro area.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

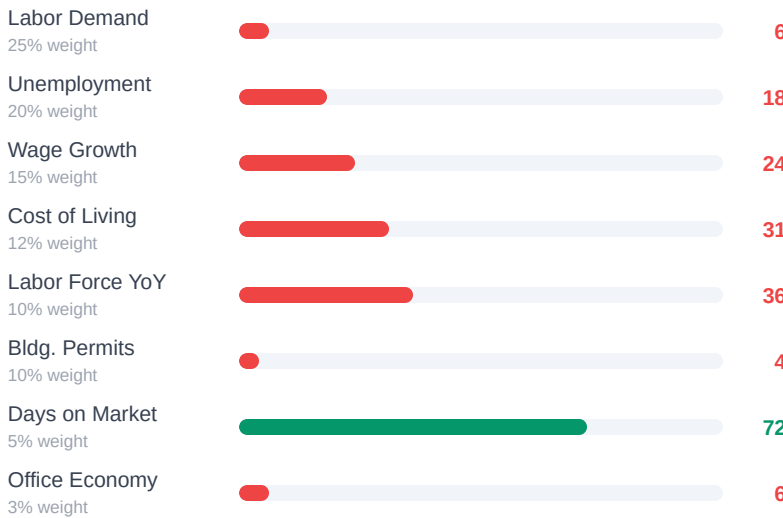
D

EMERGENCY

20.2th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-31.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
40 days
median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 20.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.11. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with an employment growth rate of -0.85% and a weekly hours deviation of +0.999%, as well as its high unemployment rate of 4.60%. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.85%, indicating a contraction in job opportunities, while the weekly hours deviation is +0.999%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, characteristic of a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.11 is in the bottom tier, ranking 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.60%, which is relatively high, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a less competitive labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.79%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may lead to a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living ratio of \$179/sqft to \$31.09/hr, with a PSF ratio of 5.76, ranking in the 31st percentile. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, but not extremely so, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. The cost of living is not decreasing, with a 0.0% YoY change in PSF.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find workers. The labor force growth rate ranks below average, in the 36th percentile.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -31.15% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals a potential supply squeeze, which may lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The building permits growth rate is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is 40 days, with a +5.3% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the area. However, this may also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.50, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers a relatively low-cost labor environment, but its low labor demand, high unemployment rate, and shrinking labor force make it a challenging location for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential supply squeeze in the housing market, which may lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

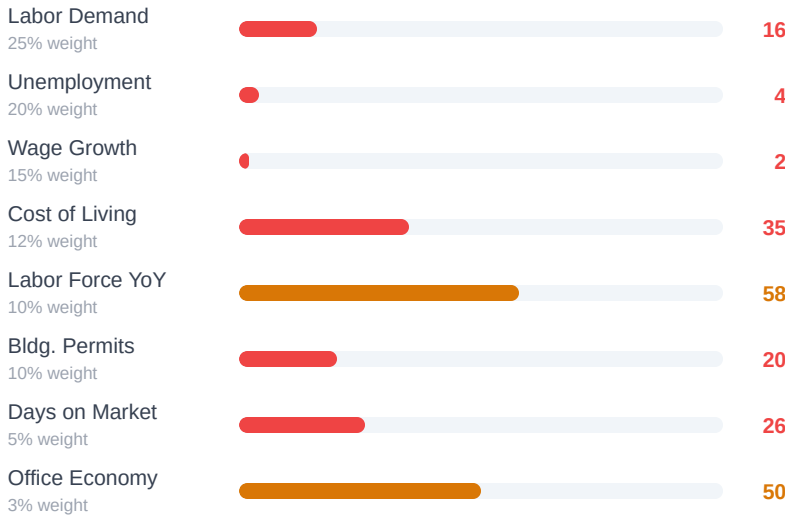
D

EMERGENCY

19.9th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days
median, -11.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.14, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and its stagnant wage growth of -0.16% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging labor market for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is -0.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.645% above its own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This indicates a lack of job creation and potential overwork for existing employees.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.70%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure and hiring challenges. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is -0.16%, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$217/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.7% year-over-year, and an earnings ratio of \$36.14/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.00, below the average. With a percentile rank of 35th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.15% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding, which could create a structural headwind for hiring and business growth. As a result, companies may face challenges in finding the talent they need to expand or maintain their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by 15.07% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits signals that the future affordability and workforce accommodation in the city may be at risk, potentially leading to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 11.9%. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive and potentially challenging housing market. However, the decreasing trend in days on market could indicate a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy percentile rank of 50th, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging labor market for businesses, with low unemployment, stagnant wage growth, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the competitive labor market and limited housing supply, which could impact business growth and expansion plans. Overall, Jacksonville's economic character requires careful consideration of labor market dynamics and potential workforce accommodation challenges.